

BUS23-1

Sales, Negotiation & Client Relations

[Module page](#)

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About this textbook

This year, for the first time, every Bachelor course at Albert School has its own textbook, thanks to your teachers and AI.

- The textbook is a help for working on the course at home, after the class.
- The course as taught in class remains the reference, and prevails over the textbook wherever the two differ.
- This is a first version. Help us improve it by sharing your feedback with your teacher.

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Preface

Marketing Fundamentals, the course before this one, told you which customer to pursue and what your offer is worth. It stopped at the edge of the conversation — the moment the customer sits across from you and says “your price is too high.” This course is about that conversation. By the end of it you will be able to do a set of things you cannot reliably do now:

- prepare a negotiation the way professionals do — compute your BATNA, MLATNA and the zone of possible agreement, and judge whether to create value or claim it;
- separate a party’s stated positions from the interests beneath them, and reopen a stalled negotiation by trading on those interests;
- apply Cialdini’s six principles and the main buyer biases to build a calibrated, honest argument — and resist those same principles when they are used on you;
- qualify a B2B opportunity, stress-test it beyond a surface qualification, run a full SPIN discovery, and apply AIDA to a B2C message;
- handle objections with technique and principle, raise a concern before the buyer does, and disclose a real product limitation in a way that builds trust;
- diagnose a sales pipeline, find its highest-leverage fixes, and run its conversion rates backwards from a revenue target to the leads it requires;
- structure a value-based price conversation — anchor, concede, and package deliberately;
- build a plan to keep and grow a client over years, not just to close the first deal;
- hold your own at a crowded, multi-party table and against hard tactics; and
- throughout, tell persuasion from manipulation and decline the manipulative move even when it would close the deal.

Marketing Fundamentals — segmentation, positioning, value-based pricing — is assumed throughout and applied, not re-taught.

1. The Harvard Negotiation Framework

1.1. A concrete deal before any theory

Two software companies are negotiating. **Vendor** sells a logistics platform; **Buyer** is a mid-size retailer. Buyer opens: “We’ll pay €80,000 a year, not a euro more.” Vendor’s salesperson, flustered, counters at €120,000, they grind to €95,000, and both leave vaguely dissatisfied — Buyer suspecting they overpaid, Vendor suspecting they left money on the table. Neither knew the one thing that actually governs the deal: **what each side would do if there were no deal at all.**

Suppose we had asked first. If Vendor walks away, its next-best use of that sales capacity is a smaller account worth €70,000 — so Vendor should never accept below €70,000. If Buyer walks away, its alternative is a rival platform that costs €110,000 all-in once migration is counted — so Buyer should never pay above €110,000. Suddenly the messy haggling has a structure: **any** number between €70,000 and €110,000 leaves both sides better off than walking away. Buyer’s “not a euro over €80,000” was a bluff, and a weak one. This is the entire machinery of formal negotiation, and we now name its parts.

1.2. BATNA: the value of walking away

Definition 1 (BATNA). Your **BATNA** — Best Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement — is the course of action you will take if this negotiation fails: the value of walking away. It anchors your **reservation value** — the worst deal you should still accept — because you should never agree to an outcome worse than what you could get without agreeing. When your best alternative is **certain**, your reservation value simply **is** your BATNA. When it is uncertain, that floor must be tempered by how likely the alternative really is — the refinement we turn to next.

The BATNA is the single most important number in any negotiation, and it is the one most people never compute. Notice what it is **not**: it is not what you hope for, not what you think is fair, not your opening demand. It is the concrete, specific thing you will actually do on Monday morning if you say no.

Example — Computing a BATNA. You are leaving your job and negotiating salary at a new firm. Your BATNA is **not** “a great salary.” It is the best concrete alternative you actually hold: the written offer from another company at €58,000, or — if you have no other offer — staying in your current job at €52,000, or unemployment. If your best real alternative is the €58,000 offer, your reservation value is €58,000: you should walk from anything below it, and you can negotiate fearlessly up to it.

Pitfall. The most common and most expensive mistake in negotiation is entering without knowing your BATNA. If you do not know your walk-away point, you cannot tell a good deal from a bad one, you concede out of fear, and a confident bluff from the other side will move you below the floor you should never have crossed. Compute your BATNA **before** the conversation, not during it.

A corollary: much of negotiation **preparation** is not rehearsing arguments but **improving your BATNA**. A second offer in hand, a credible in-house alternative, a competing supplier quote — each raises your reservation value and, with it, your power at the table. The party with the stronger BATNA can afford to walk, and both sides can feel it.

1.3. MLATNA: the alternative you'll probably get

BATNA is your **best** alternative — but the best alternative is not always the likely one. The job offer might be rescinded; the competing supplier might raise its quote. Treating a fragile best case as certain inflates your floor and makes you reject deals you should take.

Definition 2 (MLATNA). Your **MLATNA** — Most Likely Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement — is the single outcome you are **most likely** to end up with if no agreement is reached: the most probable of your possible fallbacks. When your best alternative is uncertain, the MLATNA is the more probable — and usually less rosy — fallback you should actually plan around. BATNA is the best case; MLATNA is the likely case. The two coincide only when your best alternative is also the most probable one.

Example — When BATNA and MLATNA diverge. Your BATNA is that €58,000 offer — but it is verbal, the company is restructuring, and you judge only a 40% chance it survives to a signed contract. The other 60% of the time you fall back to your current €52,000 job. Your BATNA is still €58,000 (the best case), but your MLATNA — the outcome you are **most likely** to land on — is the €52,000 job, because at 60% it is the more probable of the two. Anchoring your floor at the optimistic €58,000 risks walking away from a solid €55,000 offer in hand — a real deal — for an alternative that will probably evaporate.

Pitfall. BATNA and MLATNA answer two different questions, and conflating them is a classic error. BATNA is your **best** alternative: it tells you how strong your position could be and how boldly you can negotiate. But the floor you must not cross — your reservation value — should reflect the alternative you will **actually** fall back on. When your BATNA is certain, the two coincide and the floor is simply the BATNA. When it is shaky, set the floor nearer the MLATNA, or you will reject solid deals in hand for an alternative that may never arrive.

Remark. Do not confuse the MLATNA with the **expected value** of your alternatives — the probability-weighted average, here $0.4 \times 58,000 + 0.6 \times 52,000 = €54,400$. That average is a useful planning anchor, but it is **not** the MLATNA: it equals neither outcome that can actually occur, and it is not the most probable one either — the most probable outcome is the €52,000 job. “Most likely” picks the single likeliest outcome; the expected value blends all of them. Where exactly between the MLATNA (€52,000) and the expected value (€54,400) you set your true floor depends on your appetite for risk — but the direction is the opposite of what most people guess. A negotiator who **cannot afford** the bad outcome should set a **lower** floor: the floor is a walk-away threshold, so raising it makes you reject more offers in hand and land **more often** on the uncertain alternative — the very gamble they cannot afford. A negotiator who **can comfortably wait** can hold a **higher** floor and walk more readily, because the bad fallback does not frighten

them. This is exactly the lesson of the worked example above: the negotiator exposed to a shaky €58,000 alternative should set a **lower** floor and take the solid €55,000 in hand.

1.4. ZOPA: where a deal can live

Each side's reservation value defines a range it will accept. When those ranges overlap, a deal is possible; where they overlap is the **zone of possible agreement**.

Definition 3 (ZOPA). The **ZOPA** — Zone Of Possible Agreement — is the set of outcomes that both parties prefer to their respective BATNAs. It is bounded by the two reservation values. If the buyer's maximum is above the seller's minimum, every point between them is a deal both sides accept; if the buyer's maximum is **below** the seller's minimum, there is **no ZOPA** and no agreement should occur.

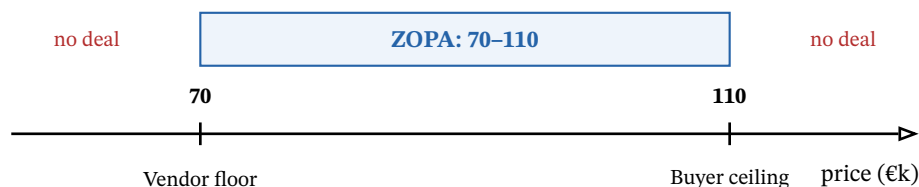


Figure 1: The ZOPA for the logistics deal. Vendor accepts anything $\geq$ €70k; Buyer accepts anything $\leq$ €110k; the overlap (€70k–€110k) is where any agreement must fall. The final price within the band is decided by negotiation skill, not by the structure.

Two facts about the ZOPA are worth holding onto. First, its **existence** is a structural fact set by the two BATNAs — no amount of charm creates a ZOPA where the ranges do not overlap. Second, **where within the ZOPA** the deal lands is the distributive contest: every euro the buyer pushes the price down is a euro out of the seller's surplus. Skill, information, and anchoring decide the split; the BATNAs decide whether a split exists at all.

Pitfall. If there is genuinely no ZOPA, the correct outcome is **no deal** — walking away is a success, not a failure. Negotiators who treat “reaching agreement” as the goal in itself sign deals worse than their BATNA just to avoid an empty-handed exit. The goal is a good outcome, which sometimes means no agreement.

1.5. Interests vs positions

So far the deal has been one-dimensional — a single price on a line. Real negotiations have many dimensions, and that is where value gets created. The key move is to stop arguing over stated demands and dig to the needs beneath them.

Definition 4 (Position vs interest). A **position** is what a party **says it wants** — a specific, stated demand (“€80,000, payment up front”). An **interest** is the underlying need or concern the position is meant to serve (“we must protect this year's cash flow”). Several different positions

can satisfy the same interest, which is precisely why uncovering interests unlocks deals that clashing positions cannot.

Example — The orange — the classic case. Two cooks fight over a single orange and compromise by cutting it in half. Only afterward does it emerge that one wanted the **juice** for a drink and the other wanted the **peel** for a cake. Their **positions** were identical (“I want the orange”) and so they fought over a fixed pie; their **interests** were completely compatible, and had either asked “why do you want it?” both could have had 100% of what they needed. Splitting the difference gave each 50% of what they wanted; trading on interests would have given each 100%.

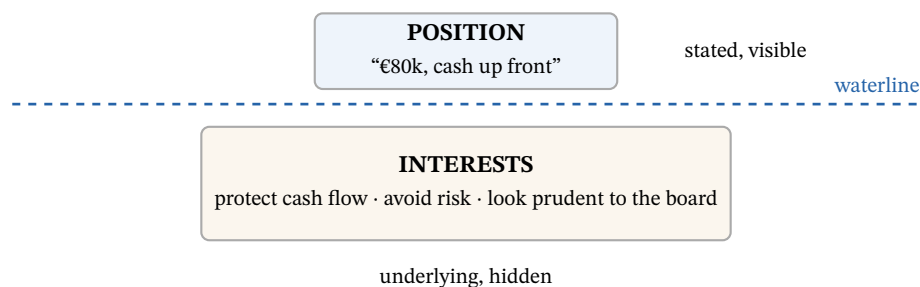


Figure 2: Positions are the visible tip; interests are the larger mass beneath. A stalled negotiation is almost always two positions colliding above the waterline. Reframing it around the interests below reopens room to trade.

Pitfall. When a negotiation stalls, the reflex is to “split the difference” between the two positions. Resist it. Splitting the difference settles the **positional** fight while leaving the **interests** unmet — often a worse outcome for both than a creative trade. Before compromising on a number, ask “why does each side want what it is demanding?” The answer frequently dissolves the deadlock entirely.

The practical skill is to take a stuck negotiation, list each side’s stated positions, ask repeatedly **why** until the interest surfaces, and then propose an option that serves both interests even if it satisfies neither original position. That move is the gateway to the next distinction.

1.6. Integrative vs distributive moves

Definition 5 (Integrative vs distributive). **Distributive** (or “claiming”) moves divide a fixed quantity of value between the parties — what one gains, the other loses (“zero-sum”; **claim the pie**). **Integrative** (or “creating”) moves enlarge the total value available by trading across issues the parties value differently (“positive-sum”; **expand the pie**). Most real negotiations require **both**: create value first, then claim a share of the larger total.

The engine of integrative bargaining is **difference**, not similarity. If you value fast payment and I value a long contract, we can trade — you get your cash timing, I get my term length, and both of us end up better off than a pure price fight would have left us. Differences in priorities, in timing, in risk tolerance, in what each side can cheaply give, are the raw material of joint gains.

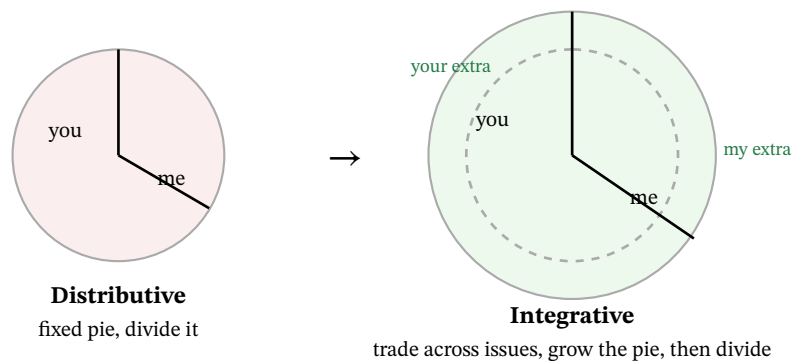


Figure 3: Distributive bargaining splits a fixed pie; integrative bargaining trades across differently-valued issues to grow the pie before splitting it. The split is the same, but the pie is larger, so **each** party's slice — “you” and “me” alike — grows past the dashed original boundary.

Example — Turning a price fight into a trade. Back to Vendor and Buyer, stuck on price. Instead of grinding on the single number, Vendor asks about interests and learns Buyer's real worry is **risk**: committing budget to a platform that might not deliver. Vendor — who is confident in the product and values **contract length** and **reference-ability** — proposes: a 2-year term (Vendor's interest) with a performance break clause and permission to use Buyer as a public reference (low cost to Buyer, high value to Vendor) in exchange for a price at the top of the ZOPA. Buyer's risk interest is met, Vendor's term and marketing interests are met, and the deal closes higher than the positional fight would have allowed. Value was **created**, then claimed.

Pitfall. Do not rush to distributive haggling before exploring integrative trades — “expand the pie before you divide it.” But the opposite error is just as costly: assuming every negotiation is integrative and refusing to claim value when the pie genuinely is fixed. A naïve cooperator who only ever creates value gets exploited by a counterpart who only claims. Read the situation: create where you can, claim where you must.

Diagnosing a scenario thus has two layers. First, compute BATNA, MLATNA, and the ZOPA to know whether and where a deal exists. Second, judge whether the situation is primarily integrative (the parties differ in ways that allow mutually beneficial trades) or distributive (they are dividing a fixed sum), and choose your moves accordingly.

Exercises

1.1. What the freelancer knows. You are offered a design project at €4,000. Your best alternative is a different project worth €3,200, but you judge it only 40% likely to materialise; if it falls through, you keep a standing retainer worth €2,000.

What the client knows. The client believes you have “plenty of other work” and expects you to negotiate hard.

Task. Compute the freelancer's BATNA and MLATNA, and state the walk-away number you would actually defend.

Debrief. Why do the BATNA and the MLATNA pull the decision in different directions here? Which one should govern the floor, and why?

1.2. What the tenant knows. You will pay at most €1,300/month for this flat; above that you would take a slightly smaller place you have already seen.

What the landlord knows. You are asking €1,500/month, but given what an empty month costs you, you would in fact accept €1,250 rather than leave it vacant.

Task. From the outside, determine whether a ZOPA exists and state it. Then name one non-price issue (lease length, deposit, repairs) the parties could trade on to create value.

Debrief. Neither side knows the other's reservation value at the table. How would each party try to discover it, and how could the wrong guess destroy a deal that a ZOPA actually supports?

1.3. What the buyer knows. (A marketing agency.) You have told a supplier you want "a 15% discount or no deal." What you actually need is to keep this year's cash outflow down; the headline rate matters to you only because your finance director tracks it.

What the seller knows. You cannot move 15% on price without breaching your own floor, but you have wide latitude on **when** you invoice.

Task. Write each side's stated **position**, dig to the **interest** beneath it by asking "why?" at least twice, and propose one integrative option that serves both interests without matching either original position.

Debrief. Which difference between the parties made the integrative trade possible? What would "splitting the difference" have left unsatisfied?

1.4. Two situations. (A) You are selling a used company van for cash. The buyer wants the lowest price, you want the highest, and price is the only term in play — one number, paid on collection. (B) You are agreeing a year-long supply contract. You care most about a long, guaranteed volume commitment that lets you plan capacity; the buyer cares most about a low unit price and the freedom to change delivery dates at short notice.

Task. For each situation, judge whether it is **primarily distributive** or **primarily integrative**, justify the call from the structure (not from the mood of the parties), and name the first move you would make.

Debrief. What structural feature of a negotiation tells you which mode it calls for — and why can reading it wrong cost you in either direction?

Answers. (1) BATNA is €3,200 — the best alternative. The MLATNA is the **most likely** outcome: the €3,200 project is only 40% likely and the €2,000 retainer is the 60% fallback, so the most probable single outcome is the retainer and MLATNA = €2,000. (The probability-weighted expected value, $0.4 \times 3200 + 0.6 \times 2000 = 2480$, is a third, distinct figure — an average, not the most likely outcome.) The €4,000 offer clears all of these, so take it. The two pull differently because the best alternative is unlikely: reading off the €3,200 BATNA you might hold out for €3,200, but since that is only 40% likely, the floor you should actually defend sits near the €2,000 you will most probably fall back on — the MLATNA should govern the floor. (2) The landlord accepts €1,250 or more, the tenant €1,300 or less, so the ZOPA is €1,250–€1,300 — a deal is possible. A non-price trade: a longer lease (security for the landlord in exchange for a lower rent), a larger deposit, or the tenant taking on minor repairs. On the debrief: each side probes with questions and small offers; if the tenant wrongly believes the landlord's floor is €1,450 and refuses to go above €1,300, both walk away from a deal that in fact existed. (3) No single key — check that each stated position (buyer: "15% off"; seller: "no more than X% off") traces to a distinct underlying interest (buyer: this year's cash outflow; seller: protecting the headline rate and floor), and that the integrative option — e.g. full price but deferred or staged invoicing — serves both interests without simply splitting the 15%. The enabling difference is that the parties value **timing** differently; splitting the difference would have left the buyer's cash-flow need unmet. (4) (A) **Primarily distributive**: a single divisible issue (price), no other terms to trade and no difference in what the parties value — every euro one gains the other loses. First move: claim well — know your BATNA, anchor on a defensible number, and concede in shrinking steps. (B) **Primarily integrative**: the parties value **different** issues (you: contract length and predictable volume; the buyer: unit price and delivery flexibility), so those differences can be traded to enlarge the deal — a longer term for a keener price, flexibility for commitment. First move: create value — surface the differing priorities and propose a trade across them **before** settling the number. The structural test is whether there is **more than one issue the parties value**

differently: several such issues make it integrative, a lone divisible issue makes it distributive. Misreading cuts both ways — treating (B) as a pure price fight leaves joint gains unclaimed, while treating (A) as integrative wastes effort inventing trades that do not exist and invites a pure claimer to exploit you.

Chapter takeaways. BATNA (best alternative) sets your walk-away floor; MLATNA (most likely alternative) tempers it by probability. The ZOPA is the overlap of both reservation values — no overlap, no deal. Positions are stated demands; interests are the needs beneath them, and trading on interests unlocks integrative (“expand the pie”) moves, as opposed to distributive (“divide the pie”) ones. Diagnose every scenario on both axes: where the deal can live, and whether to create or claim.

2. The Psychology of Influence

2.1. Why structure isn't enough

The last chapter gave you the architecture of a deal. But people are not spreadsheets: the same offer, framed two ways, lands differently; the same price, anchored high or low, feels expensive or cheap. Influence is the study of the predictable, non-rational ways human judgment moves — and a negotiator who ignores it will be out-played by one who does not, even with an identical BATNA.

2.2. Cialdini's six principles

A software buyer stalls for weeks — until the rep mentions that four other firms in her sector adopted the tool last quarter. She signs within the week. Nothing about the product changed; she simply saw that comparable others had chosen it, and that tipped her. That pull — following the crowd under uncertainty — is one of six that Robert Cialdini, after years studying compliance professionals, distilled from how people are moved to say yes. Each is a reliable shortcut the human mind takes, and each can **serve** a buyer's real interest or **exploit** it; we meet the honest use here and the exploitative twin in Chapter 9.

Definition 6 (Cialdini's six principles of influence).

1. **Reciprocity** — people feel obliged to repay what they receive. A genuine concession, a useful sample, or real help creates a pull to give back.
2. **Commitment and consistency** — people act in line with what they have already said or done, especially publicly. Small initial agreements pave the way to larger ones.
3. **Social proof** — people look to what comparable others do, especially under uncertainty. “Firms like yours chose this” reduces perceived risk.
4. **Authority** — people defer to credible expertise. Demonstrated competence and legitimate credentials carry disproportionate weight.
5. **Liking** — people say yes more readily to those they like, and liking grows from similarity, genuine compliments, and cooperation toward shared goals.
6. **Scarcity** — people value what is limited or fleeting more highly; a real deadline or limited availability raises urgency and perceived worth.

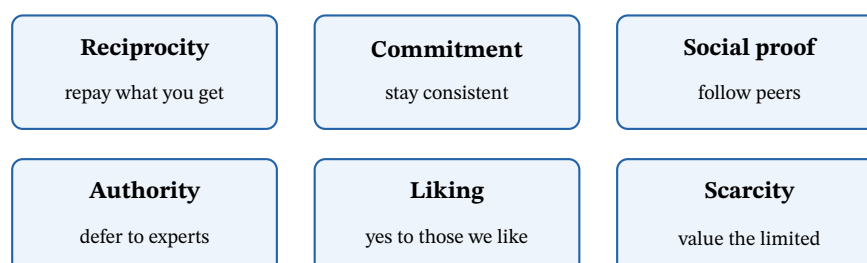


Figure 4: Cialdini's six principles. Each is a mental shortcut buyers use under uncertainty — a tool of persuasion when the underlying claim is true, and of manipulation when it is manufactured (see Chapter 9).

Example — Calibrating principles to one buyer. You are selling a project-management tool to a cautious operations director at a conservative manufacturer. Using all six principles at once

would feel clumsy and staged. Calibration means choosing the two or three that fit **this** person: **authority** (a case study from a respected industrial peer), **social proof** (a named list of similar manufacturers already using it), and **commitment** (a small low-risk pilot they agree to first, which makes the later full rollout consistent with a choice they already made). Scarcity and heavy liking-based charm would **reduce** trust with this buyer. The principle is not “use all six”; it is “use the ones the interlocutor is actually moved by.”

Pitfall. The beginner uses every principle on every buyer — a fake deadline, a flattering compliment, a name-drop, and a free gift all in one breath. Calibrated influence does the opposite: it selects the few principles suited to the specific person and situation. Over-application reads as a sales script and **destroys** credibility, which is the very thing authority and liking depend on.

2.3. Buyer cognitive biases

Quote a buyer a €2,000 “standard price” and then offer €900, and the €900 feels like a gift — even if nothing ever sold at €2,000. Describe a treatment as “95% success” and it reassures; call the same fact “1-in-20 failure” and it alarms. Warn a buyer that inaction will **lose** them €50k and they move faster than if you promise to **gain** them the same €50k. Three predictable distortions are at work in those three moments, and they shape how every buyer evaluates an offer.

Definition 7 (Anchoring, framing, loss aversion).

- **Anchoring** — judgments are pulled toward whatever reference number is presented first. The opening figure in a price conversation drags the final figure toward it, even when the anchor is arbitrary.
- **Framing** — the same fact is evaluated differently depending on how it is presented. “95% success rate” and “1-in-20 failure rate” are identical facts that feel opposite.
- **Loss aversion** — a loss looms larger than an equivalent gain (roughly twice as large). People work harder to avoid losing something than to gain the same thing.

Example — The three biases in a single pitch. Selling a security audit: you **anchor** by mentioning that a comparable breach cost a peer firm €2M before naming your €40k fee — against which the fee now feels small. You **frame** the service as “protecting the €2M you already have” rather than “a chance to improve security,” because the protective frame engages **loss aversion** — the buyer fights harder to avoid the €2M loss than to capture an abstract gain. None of this is false; the breach cost is real and the risk is real. That is what keeps it persuasion rather than manipulation.

Pitfall. Biases cut both ways: the buyer is anchored by your opening number, but **you** are anchored by theirs. When a buyer opens with an aggressive lowball, the danger is that it silently resets your sense of the ZOPA. Recognise the anchor as a tactic, mentally discard it, and re-anchor against your own prepared figure rather than negotiating down from theirs.

A first ethical flag, developed fully in Chapter 9: every principle and bias in this chapter has a manipulative twin. Anchoring on a **real** comparable cost is persuasion; anchoring on a **fabricated**

“list price” no one ever paid is manipulation. The mechanics are identical; the truth of the underlying claim, and whether the buyer’s genuine interest is served, is what separates them.

2.4. Resisting the same principles when they target you

A vendor buys you lunch, hands you a free trial, then asks for the order — and you feel the tug to give something back. The defence is not to refuse the lunch; it is to ask yourself one question first: **would I want this if no favour had come with it?** These principles work on you exactly as they work on your buyer — you are the interlocutor in someone else’s negotiation more often than you are the seller in your own — and the most reliable defence is a single prepared question for each, one that interrupts the automatic response long enough to let you decide on the merits.

Framework 1 (One question or behaviour that resists each principle).

- **Reciprocity** — “Would I want this if no gift came with it?” A favour or free sample obliges nothing; you may accept it and still decline.
- **Commitment and consistency** — “Would I choose this today if I had not already said yes to the small first step?” Judge the decision on its current merits, not on staying consistent with a foot in the door.
- **Social proof** — “Do those others actually share my situation and my constraints?” A crowd that differs from you is no evidence for your choice.
- **Authority** — “What is the evidence, and does this person’s expertise really cover **this** question?” Separate genuine competence from its trappings — a title, a confident tone, a uniform.
- **Liking** — “Would I accept this offer from someone I disliked?” Rate the deal, not the rapport.
- **Scarcity** — “Is the limit real, and would I want this regardless of the deadline?” Verify the constraint, then decide on need, not on urgency.

The same two biases have defences too: against **anchoring**, name the opening number as a tactic and re-anchor on your own prepared figure (the pitfall above); against **framing**, restate the fact in the opposite frame and check whether your judgment moves; against **loss aversion**, ask whether you are avoiding a loss that is real or merely one the seller has manufactured.

Exercises

2.1. What the buyer knows. You are Dpt Head at a conservative, family-owned manufacturer. You distrust slick vendors, value the judgment of respected industry peers, and will not sign anything without a small trial first.

What the seller knows. You sell a project-management tool. You have a case study from a respected industrial peer, a named list of similar manufacturers already using it, and you can offer a low-risk pilot.

Task. Write a short pitch that deliberately uses exactly three of Cialdini’s six principles, chosen to fit this buyer. Name the three, and name the ones you deliberately left out.

Debrief. Why would using all six at once have **reduced** this buyer’s trust?

2.2. What the buyer knows. You are a risk-averse operations manager weighing a safety product. You dislike gambles and hate being blamed for a preventable failure.

What the seller knows. Your product’s single factual claim is that it “works 9 times out of 10.”

Task. Write that same claim once in a **gain** frame and once in a **loss** frame. Say which is more persuasive to this buyer.

Debrief. Which cognitive bias predicts the answer, and why?

2.3. What the seller knows. (You are the buyer here.) A salesperson wants to close you today. They mention that “our biggest competitor already switched,” that “this price holds only until Friday,” and they open by quoting a €2,000 “list price” before offering it to you for €900.

What you (the buyer) know. You have not verified any of these three claims.

Task. Name the influence principle or bias behind each of the three moves, and write the one question you would ask yourself to resist each.

Debrief. Which of the three, if true, would be legitimate persuasion — and what single fact would you need to check to know?

Answers. (1) No single key — check **calibration**: exactly three principles that genuinely fit this buyer (authority via the peer case study, social proof via the named list, commitment via the pilot), a stated reason each fits, and at least one deliberately left out (scarcity and heavy liking-based charm would reduce this buyer’s trust). Over-application reads as a script and destroys the very credibility authority and liking depend on. (2) The **loss** frame is more persuasive to a risk-averse buyer. Gain frame: “works 9 times out of 10”; loss frame: “fails 1 time in 10 — don’t be the one left exposed.” **Loss aversion** predicts this: a prospective loss looms roughly twice as large as the equivalent gain, so the same fact framed as a loss to be avoided engages more urgency. (3) “Competitor switched” = **social proof**, resisted by “does that firm share my situation and constraints?”; “only until Friday” = **scarcity**, resisted by “is the deadline real, and would I want this regardless of it?”; the €2,000 list price = **anchoring**, resisted by naming it as a tactic and re-anchoring on what the thing is actually worth to you. Any of the three can be legitimate persuasion if the underlying claim is **true** — the competitor really did switch, the deadline is real, €2,000 is a price the item genuinely sold at — which is the single fact to check in each case.

Chapter takeaways. Cialdini’s six principles — reciprocity, commitment, social proof, authority, liking, scarcity — are mental shortcuts buyers use, and the skill is **calibration**: selecting the few that fit a specific interlocutor, not using all six at once. Three biases shape buyer judgment: anchoring (pull toward the first number), framing (presentation changes evaluation), and loss aversion (losses outweigh gains). Every one of these is dual-use; the line to manipulation is taken up in Chapter 9.

3. The Structured Sales Cycle

3.1. From “always be closing” to “always be diagnosing”

The folklore of selling is the smooth talker who charms a reluctant buyer into signing. But watch two reps sell the same database tool: the first walks the buyer through every feature in the opening meeting and loses; the second spends that meeting asking how the buyer’s team loses time today, names a cost the buyer had never added up, and wins. Decades of evidence on **complex, high-value B2B sales** say the second rep is the rule, not the exception: in big deals, success turns far more on the quality of the seller’s **questions** — their diagnosis of the buyer’s problem — than on the polish of the close. The philosophy behind this shift has a name.

Definition 8 (Consultative selling). **Consultative selling** casts the seller as a **diagnostician** of the buyer’s problem rather than a promoter of a product. The seller’s first job is to understand the buyer’s situation and **create customer value** — helping the buyer see a real problem, and its cost, more clearly than before — and only then to position the offer as its solution. It is the opposite of **product-led** selling, which pushes features before the need is understood. A consultative seller earns the right to propose by first having genuinely understood.

Everything in this chapter operationalises that stance. We build the structured B2B cycle in two stages: qualify the opportunity (BANT), then run the discovery (SPIN) — both of which are disciplines of **understanding before proposing**.

3.2. BANT: deciding whether to invest at all

An enthusiastic junior manager keeps booking demos of your platform — but has no budget this year, cannot sign, and won’t decide before “maybe next year.” Every hour you pour into her is an hour stolen from a buyer who could actually close. Selling effort is finite, so deciding **early**, and on evidence rather than enthusiasm, whether a prospect is worth pursuing is its own discipline.

Definition 9 (BANT). **BANT** qualifies an opportunity on four criteria:

- **Budget** — can the prospect afford it, and is money allocated?
- **Authority** — is your contact the decision-maker, or who is?
- **Need** — is there a real, acknowledged problem your offer solves?
- **Timeline** — is there a date by which they intend to decide or act?

An opportunity weak on several criteria is not yet worth advancing, and qualifying it **out** is a legitimate, valuable outcome.

Example — Qualifying a prospect with BANT. An enthusiastic junior manager wants demo after demo of your analytics platform. Running BANT: **Budget** — none allocated this year. **Authority** — she cannot sign; her VP can. **Need** — real, but not urgent. **Timeline** — “maybe next year.” The deal is poorly qualified. Rather than pour weeks of demos into it, the disciplined move is to invest lightly, build the relationship, and ask to be introduced to the VP — while spending your real selling time on opportunities that pass BANT now.

Pitfall. Happy ears — hearing enthusiasm and mistaking it for a deal — is the classic failure. An eager contact with no budget, no authority, and no timeline is not a hot lead; they are a time sink. Qualify honestly and early, and be willing to walk away from a friendly prospect who will never buy.

3.3. Where BANT runs out: complex B2B

BANT is a fast screen, and in a simple sale it is enough. But in a complex B2B deal — several stakeholders, a long cycle, a formal purchasing process — an opportunity can pass all four BANT criteria and still die. Budget, a contact, a need, and a timeline tell you the deal **could** happen; they do not tell you **how** it will actually get decided. Three questions probe that.

Framework 2 (Stress-testing a qualified opportunity). Beyond BANT, an apparently qualified complex deal must survive three further tests:

- **Decision process** — how does this organisation actually buy? Who else signs off, what stages (legal, security, procurement) does it pass through, and how long does each take? A deal with no mapped process stalls in stages you never saw coming.
- **Decision criteria** — what explicit criteria will they judge the options against, and do those criteria favour you or a competitor? If the criteria are written around a rival's strengths, the deal is lost before the demo.
- **Internal champion** — is there someone **inside** the account who argues for you when you are not in the room? Without a champion, your case is only as strong as your last meeting.

Pitfall. A deal that looks qualified on BANT can be quietly doomed: the budget is real but controlled by a finance committee you have never met (decision process); the need is real but the written criteria were drafted by a competitor's advocate (decision criteria); the contact is enthusiastic but silent internally (no champion). Stress-test every complex opportunity against these three before you forecast it as winnable.

Remark. More detailed qualification frameworks exist for exactly these gaps — the best known is **MEDDIC**, used by many complex-B2B sales teams to formalise metrics, the economic buyer, decision criteria, decision process, pain, and champion. We do not teach it here; the point to carry is only that BANT is a screen, not a guarantee, and that a complex deal needs the deeper questions above.

3.4. SPIN: the four question types

Once an opportunity is qualified, the heart of the B2B sale is **discovery**. Ask a clinic manager “how do you book patients today?” and you learn they use a paper diary; ask “what does a no-show cost you?” and **she** works out it is €40k a year. The second question did what the first could not — it turned a tolerated nuisance into an urgent, quantified problem, in the buyer's own words. Neil Rackham, from analysing thousands of real sales calls, found four question types that do this in sequence, carrying a buyer from a vague, **latent** need to an explicit, urgent one.

Definition 10 (SPIN). SPIN structures discovery through four question types, used in rough sequence:

- **Situation** — establish the facts of the buyer’s current context (“How do you handle X today? How many people are involved?”).
- **Problem** — surface difficulties and dissatisfactions (“Where does that process break down? What frustrates you about it?”).
- **Implication** — develop the **consequences** and cost of those problems (“What does that delay cost you per month? How does it affect your other teams?”).
- **Need-payoff** — have the **buyer** articulate the value of solving it (“If that were fixed, what would it be worth to you?”).

The power is in the order: implication and need-payoff questions convert a problem the buyer had learned to live with into one they urgently want solved — and let the **buyer**, not the seller, voice the value.

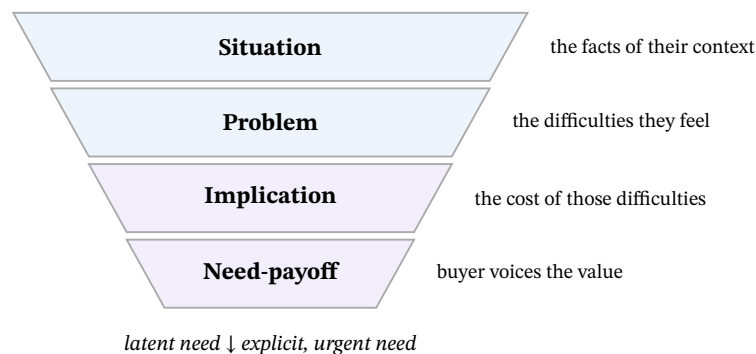


Figure 5: The SPIN funnel. Questions narrow from broad context (Situation) to the buyer’s own statement of value (Need-payoff). Implication and need-payoff questions do the heavy lifting: they make a tolerated problem feel urgent.

Example — A SPIN sequence in miniature. Selling a scheduling tool to a clinic manager:

- **S:** “How do you book patients today?” — “Phone and a paper diary.”
- **P:** “Does anything go wrong with that?” — “We double-book sometimes, and no-shows are high.”
- **I:** “What does a no-show cost you?” — “About €80 of idle clinician time, maybe ten a week.” (The buyer has just computed €800/week — €40k/year — out loud.)
- **N:** “If you could halve no-shows with automated reminders, what would that be worth?” — “€20k a year, easily, plus less stress.”

Notice the seller never claimed a number. The **buyer** quantified the problem and voiced the payoff — far more convincing than any pitch.

The question **types** are only half the discipline; the **quality** of each question decides whether discovery works. This is what a post-hoc critique of a sales call should judge — and it matters more than how smoothly you closed.

Framework 3 (The marks of a good discovery question). A good discovery question:

- **sounds natural**, like genuine curiosity, not a line read from a script;

- **builds on the buyer's own previous answer**, reusing their words rather than resetting to a fixed list;
- **does not ask what research would have answered** — never spend the buyer's time on facts you could have looked up (“so, what does your company do?”);
- **does not lead the buyer toward your product** — “wouldn't it help to have X?” is a pitch in disguise, not discovery.

And it respects the order: establish **reality** first (Situation, Problem), then **impact** (Implication), then **value** (Need-payoff). Ask for value before the buyer feels the impact and the payoff rings hollow.

Pitfall. The novice rushes through Situation and Problem to get to the pitch, skipping Implication entirely. That is the costliest omission in B2B selling: without implication questions, the buyer never feels the **cost** of inaction, the need stays latent, and the deal stalls at “interesting, let me think about it.” A SPIN call is judged on the depth of discovery — Situation, Problem, and above all Implication — not on closing style.

Remark. Note how SPIN operationalises the previous chapters. Implication questions make the **loss** of inaction vivid (loss aversion); need-payoff has the buyer make a small verbal **commitment** to the value (consistency). And the whole method is really interest-discovery from Chapter 1 — Situation and Problem questions surface the buyer's true interests beneath their initial position.

3.5. AIDA for B2C

SPIN assumes an identifiable buyer, a complex problem, and time to talk. Much B2C selling has none of these — a shopper thumbing past an ad, a customer in a checkout queue, a one-to-many message with no dialogue at all. Think of a poster that stops you with a question, holds you with one relevant line, makes you want the thing, and tells you exactly how to buy it, all before your bus arrives. For that world the classic model is AIDA, which describes not the **questions to ask** but the **stages of attention** a message must move a buyer through.

Definition 11 (AIDA). AIDA models a buyer's progression through four mental stages that a seller's message must move them along:

- **Attention** — get noticed at all amid the clutter.
- **Interest** — engage them enough to keep paying attention.
- **Desire** — make them **want** the product.
- **Action** — prompt the concrete step (buy, sign up, click) now.

It is a one-directional **funnel of attention**, suited to shorter, lower-stakes purchases and one-to-many communication.

The two middle stages are the ones beginners blur, and keeping them apart is the whole craft of a B2C message. **Interest** is **cognitive**: the buyer registers that the message is relevant to them and keeps paying attention. **Desire** is **motivational**: the buyer now **wants** the thing. You can hold someone's

interest and still leave them wanting nothing — so the move from Interest to Desire has to be built deliberately.

Framework 4 (Building Desire: feature → benefit → outcome). Desire is manufactured by climbing a ladder, not by listing specifications:

- a **feature** is what the product **has** (“a memory-foam layer”);
- a **benefit** is what that feature **does** for the buyer (“even pressure relief”);
- a **customer outcome** is the changed situation the buyer **ends up in** (“you wake up rested and stop dreading mornings”).

Interest can rest on a feature; Desire lives at the outcome rung. Two further moves deepen it: **proof and risk reduction** — testimonials, ratings, guarantees, and free trials that lower the buyer’s fear of choosing wrong — make the buyer want the product **more**. And **Action** is carried by a clear, **low-friction** call to action: one obvious next step with the effort stripped out. A vague or costly ask (“contact us to learn more”) loses buyers who had already reached Desire.

Example — AIDA in a single advertisement. A direct-to-consumer mattress ad. “Still waking up tired?” grabs **Attention**. A few seconds on how poor sleep wrecks your focus and mood holds **Interest** — it is clearly about the viewer. Then **Desire** is built up the ladder: not “12 cm of memory foam” (feature) but “pressure spread evenly so you stop tossing” (benefit) rising to “wake up rested, sharp by 9 a.m.” (outcome) — reinforced by proof and risk reduction: “23,000 five-star reviews, 100-night trial, full refund if you don’t sleep better.” Finally **Action**: “Order tonight — one click, free returns, ships tomorrow,” the next step made frictionless. No discovery, no dialogue — the message alone carries the buyer through all four stages in thirty seconds.

3.6. When are SPIN and AIDA interchangeable?

A frequent confusion is to treat these as rival templates and ask which is “better.” Try SPIN’s patient questioning on a customer grabbing a phone charger and they walk before your second question; run AIDA’s “create desire, drive action” push on a €2M deal with a six-person committee and you pressure people who have not yet understood their own problem. Each model has a home, and the honest answer is about **boundary conditions**.

	SPIN fits	AIDA fits
Buyer	single, identifiable	many, anonymous
Interaction	two-way dialogue	one-to-many message
Offer	complex, high-stakes	simple, low-stakes
Cycle	long, considered	short, often impulse
Mechanism	diagnostic questions	attention funnel

Figure 6: SPIN and AIDA fit opposite ends of the buying spectrum. They are interchangeable only where the contexts overlap — a single buyer, a simple offer, a short cycle — and not where complex multi-stakeholder discovery is required.

Definition 12 (Boundary conditions). **SPIN** fits complex, considered, high-value sales with an identifiable buyer and a problem that can be developed through dialogue. **AIDA** fits short, lower-consideration, often one-to-many purchases where there is no discovery conversation. They become **interchangeable** only when the buying context collapses the difference — a single buyer, a simple offer, a short cycle (a small in-store sale, say). They are **not** interchangeable where multi-stakeholder discovery is required: AIDA has no mechanism for it, and SPIN is impossible without a dialogue.

Pitfall. Importing the wrong model is a real and common error. Run a pure AIDA “create desire, drive action” push on a €2M enterprise deal with a six-person buying committee and you will pressure a buyer who has not yet understood their own problem — the deal stalls. Conversely, attempt patient SPIN discovery on an impulse retail purchase and the customer walks before question two. Match the model to the buying context, not to habit.

Remark. This mirrors B2B-vs-B2C from *Marketing Fundamentals*: the strategic doctrine is invariant but its **texture** changes with the buyer. SPIN and AIDA are that texture made operational — the same goal (move a buyer to a yes) executed differently depending on whether you face one deliberating buyer or a crowd of fast ones.

Exercises

3.1. What the buyer knows. You are an ops lead at a 400-person firm. There is budget “in principle,” you are keen, but any purchase over €50k goes through a finance committee and a security review, and your CFO ultimately signs. A rival vendor’s champion helped draft the evaluation checklist last year.

What the seller knows. You sell a €90k analytics platform. Your enthusiastic contact is the ops lead above.

Task. Qualify this opportunity against all four BANT criteria, then stress-test it on decision process, decision criteria, and internal champion. State whether you would advance it and what you would do next.

Debrief. BANT looks green here. Which of the three deeper tests is the real threat, and why can an opportunity pass BANT and still be unwinnable?

3.2. What the buyer knows. (A clinic manager.) You book patients with a paper diary, double-book “sometimes,” and have high no-shows, but you have never added up what any of it costs and you assume “that’s just how clinics run.”

What the seller knows. You sell a scheduling tool with automated reminders.

Task. Script a short SPIN sequence — two questions of each type (Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff) — in which the Implication questions push the buyer to **quantify** the cost and the Need-payoff questions make the **buyer** state the value.

Debrief. Critique your own script on the four marks of a good discovery question and on the reality → impact → value order — not on how you would close.

3.3. What the buyer knows. You are a tired commuter scrolling your phone at night; you are not shopping for anything in particular.

What the seller knows. You are marketing a B2C product of your choice through a single short advertisement — no dialogue, one shot to convert.

Task. Write the ad so it visibly moves through all four AIDA stages. Label each line, and show Desire climbing the feature → benefit → outcome ladder with at least one proof/risk-reduction element and a low-friction call to action.

Debrief. Which line does the Interest-to-Desire work, and how would the ad read if it stopped at features?

3.4. What the buyer knows. Case A: you are one shopper buying a €30 kettle in a shop. Case B: you are a six-person committee buying a €2M enterprise system.

What the seller knows. The same seller must choose SPIN or AIDA for each.

Task. State, for each case, whether SPIN and AIDA are interchangeable and name the boundary condition that decides it. Then explain concretely what goes wrong if a pure AIDA “create desire, drive action” push is run on Case B.

Debrief. What single feature of the buying context flips the answer between the two cases?

Answers. (1) BANT: **Budget** in principle but not confirmed; **Authority** — your contact is not the signer, the CFO is; **Need** — real; **Timeline** — gated by committee and security review. Even read generously, the deeper tests expose the danger: the **decision process** (finance committee + security review + CFO sign-off) is long and unmapped, and above all the **decision criteria** were shaped by a rival’s champion, while you have **no internal champion** of your own. The real threat is the criteria/champion pair: advance only by getting to the CFO, mapping the process, and recruiting a champion — otherwise the deal is lost before the demo. An opportunity passes BANT yet loses because BANT is a screen for **whether** a deal could exist, not for **how** it gets decided. (2) Check eight questions, two per type; the two Implication questions must drive toward a **quantified** cost (e.g. “what does one no-show cost in idle clinician time? how many a week?”), and the Need-payoff questions must ask the **buyer** to state the value (“if you halved no-shows, what would that be worth?”). A sound self-critique judges the questions on the four marks (natural, builds on the last answer, not answerable by research, not leading to the product) and on the reality → impact → value order — not on closing polish. (3) Check four labelled lines: Attention grabs notice, Interest holds it (relevance), Desire climbs feature → benefit → outcome with a proof/risk-reduction element, Action gives one low-friction step. Stopping at features leaves Interest without Desire — nobody wants a specification. (4) Case A (single buyer, simple low-stakes offer, short cycle): **interchangeable** — the context collapses the difference. Case B: **not** — multi-stakeholder discovery is required, which AIDA cannot do and SPIN needs a dialogue for. The deciding boundary condition is the presence of a diagnostic dialogue over a complex, considered purchase. A pure AIDA push on Case B pressures a committee that has not yet understood its own problem: no Implication questions, so the need stays latent, the deal stalls at “interesting, let me think about it,” and no one-to-many message reaches every stakeholder.

Chapter takeaways. Qualify before you invest: BANT (Budget, Authority, Need, Timeline) screens opportunities, and qualifying **out** is a win — but in complex B2B, stress-test an apparently qualified deal on decision process, decision criteria, and internal champion (BANT is only a screen, not a guarantee). Run discovery with SPIN — Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff — whose engine is the implication and need-payoff questions; judge a call on discovery quality (natural, builds on the last answer, not research or a pitch; reality → impact → value), not on closing flash. AIDA — Attention, Interest, Desire, Action — is the one-to-many funnel for short B2C purchases: keep Interest (cognitive) apart from Desire (motivational), build Desire up the feature → benefit → outcome ladder with proof and a low-friction call to action. SPIN and AIDA are interchangeable only where the context collapses (single buyer, simple offer, short cycle) and not where multi-stakeholder discovery is required.

4. Objection Handling and Closing

4.1. An objection is information, not an attack

Beginners hear an objection — “it’s too expensive,” “we’re happy with our current supplier” — as rejection, and either fold or argue. Both are wrong. An objection is the buyer **telling you what stands between them and yes**. Handled well, it is the most useful moment in the conversation. This chapter covers three techniques, and — crucially — the **tactical principle** behind each, because the goal is to understand the move, not memorise a script.

4.2. Feel-Felt-Found

Buyer: “Honestly, we’re happy with our current supplier.” The weak reply argues straight back — “but we do more than they do” — and the buyer digs in. The strong reply **agrees** first: “That makes sense — you’ve built a relationship there, and switching is a real hassle.” Only once the buyer feels heard does your evidence get through. That three-beat move has a name.

Definition 13 (Feel-Felt-Found). A three-step response to an objection: **acknowledge** the buyer’s reaction (“I understand how you **feel**”), **normalise** it with the experience of others (“other clients **felt** the same way”), and **resolve** it with evidence (“what they **found** was...”). Its tactical principle is **acknowledgment before counter**: lowering the buyer’s defensiveness by validating the objection **before** addressing it, so your evidence is heard rather than resisted.

Example — Feel-Felt-Found on a price objection. Buyer: “This is more expensive than the tool we use now.” Seller: “I completely understand how you feel — the sticker price is higher (**feel**). A lot of our clients felt exactly that when they compared the two (**felt**). What they found after switching was that the time saved on manual reconciliation paid back the difference within four months (**found**).” The objection is acknowledged, the buyer feels understood rather than argued with, and the evidence lands.

Pitfall. Feel-Felt-Found degrades into a transparent script if recited mechanically — a buyer who hears a robotic “I understand how you feel, others felt the same” feels handled, not heard. The **principle** (acknowledge genuinely before countering) matters more than the exact words; vary the phrasing and mean the acknowledgment.

4.3. Reframing

“Too expensive,” says the buyer, and the reflex is to defend the price. Instead, change what it is being compared **against**: “expensive next to what — including what the unsolved problem costs you every month it goes unfixed?” The objection was only valid inside the buyer’s original frame; move the comparison to another frame and the answer changes.

Definition 14 (Reframing). **Reframing** restates an objection inside a different frame so it no longer blocks the decision. A **price** objection (“too expensive”) is reframed as a **value** or **cost-of-inaction** question (“expensive compared to what — including the cost of the problem staying unsolved?”). The tactical principle is **changing the frame of comparison**: the objection was valid only within the buyer’s original frame, so you move the comparison to a frame where the answer differs.

This is the negotiation cousin of competitive framing from *Marketing Fundamentals*: a €4 energy bar is “expensive” framed against a snack and “cheap” framed against a meal. The same product, reframed, changes the answer to the objection.

Example — Reframing ‘no budget’. Buyer: “We don’t have budget for this.” Reframe: “I hear you — there’s no line item for it. Can I ask, what is the **unsolved** problem costing you each month right now? If it’s €10k, then the real question isn’t whether there’s budget, it’s whether €10k a month is an acceptable place to keep it.” The objection (“no budget”) is reframed as a comparison between the cost of the tool and the cost of inaction.

4.4. Strategic silence

You name your price and the buyer says nothing. Three seconds stretch out, the quiet feels unbearable, and the untrained seller caves — “...of course, there’s some room to move” — conceding before the buyer has said a word. The trained seller holds the silence and lets the buyer break it first.

Definition 15 (Strategic silence). **Strategic silence** is the deliberate withholding of speech after you make an offer, ask a closing question, or hear an objection. Its tactical principle is **using the other party’s discomfort with silence**: most people rush to fill a pause, and the one who speaks first often concedes, reveals information, or talks themselves toward yes. Make your statement, then stop.

Example — Silence after the price. “The investment for the full package is €60,000.” ...and then nothing. The inexperienced seller, anxious, immediately adds “...but we could probably do something on that” — conceding before the buyer has said a word. The disciplined seller states the number and stays quiet. The buyer fills the silence, often with useful information (“that’s a bit more than we hoped”) that reveals where the real negotiation is.

Pitfall. The single most expensive habit in closing is **talking past the close** — making the ask or stating the price and then nervously continuing, qualifying, discounting, or back-peddalling into the silence. Ask, then be quiet. Let the other person carry the burden of the pause.

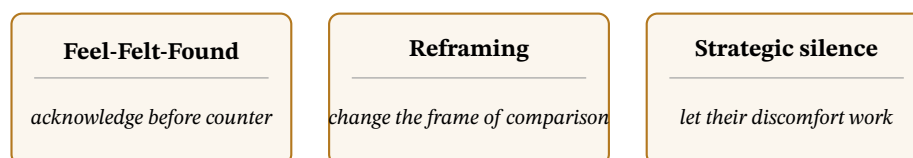


Figure 7: Three objection-handling moves, each defined by its tactical principle. Handling an objection well means naming the principle that applies and choosing the move — not reciting a memorised line.

4.5. Getting ahead of the objection

The three moves above are **reactive** — they answer an objection once it lands. But you often know what the buyer will worry about before they say it. Rather than wait for “how does this work with our old ERP?”, the most credible sellers raise it first: “You’re probably wondering about the ERP integration — let me deal with that now.” Naming the concern yourself signals you are not hiding it.

Definition 16 (Proactive objection management). **Proactive objection management** is surfacing a concern you know the buyer is likely to have — **before** they raise it (“You’re probably wondering how this handles your existing ERP; let me deal with that now”). Its tactical principle is **disarming by pre-empting**: naming the concern yourself signals you are not hiding it, defuses its emotional charge, and lets you frame it on your terms rather than on the defensive.

The sharpest form of this is admitting what your product does **not** do. Handled well, an honest limitation **builds** credibility — it proves your other claims are not sales talk — provided you do one thing: say **for whom the limitation matters and for whom it does not**. A limitation stated in the abstract scares everyone; a limitation located (“it matters if... it never comes up if...”) lets the right buyer see it does not apply to them, and lets the wrong buyer self-select out early, which serves you both.

Definition 17 (Honest disclosure of a limitation). **Honest disclosure** names a genuine product weakness and then **locates** it: the segment or use-case for whom it is a real constraint, and the segment for whom it is irrelevant. The credibility comes from the locating — a blanket “nothing’s perfect” concedes nothing useful; “this is a real problem **if** you do X, and a non-issue **if** you do Y” shows you understand the buyer’s situation well enough to tell which they are.

Example — Disclosing a limitation, located. “I should be straight with you: our platform has no offline mode — it needs a live connection. If your field teams work in warehouses or basements with no signal, that’s a genuine constraint and you should weigh it seriously. But for an office-based team on stable wifi, like yours, it simply never comes up.” The seller has disclosed a real weakness, said exactly **for whom** it bites and **for whom** it does not, and — because this buyer is in the second group — turned a confession into a proof of honesty.

Pitfall. Do not “disclose” a fake or trivial weakness to seem honest (“our only flaw is we care too much”). Buyers see through it, and it burns the credibility the move is supposed to earn. Disclose a **real** limitation, and always locate it — an unlocated admission (“it can be slow sometimes”) just plants a doubt you never resolve.

Exercises

4.1. What the buyer knows. You run operations and are comparing tools. You have three worries you have voiced: “too expensive,” “we’re happy with our current vendor,” and “now isn’t a good time.”

What the seller knows. Each worry is an objection you can work, not a rejection.

Task. For each of the three objections, write one Feel-Felt-Found response and one reframe, and name the tactical principle each relies on.

Debrief. Why does “acknowledge before counter” make Feel-Felt-Found more effective than an immediate rebuttal? Tie it to buyer defensiveness.

4.2. What the buyer knows. You think €60,000 is more than you hoped to spend, but you have not said so yet.

What the seller knows. You have just stated the €60,000 price and are tempted to soften it immediately.

Task. Script the closing exchange so the seller uses **strategic silence** after the price. Show what the buyer reveals by filling the pause.

Debrief. What would the seller have given away by speaking first?

4.3. What the buyer knows. Your team is office-based on stable wifi. You will ask, eventually, whether the tool works offline.

What the seller knows. Your product has no offline mode — a real limitation, but one that does not affect this buyer.

Task. Write how you would **proactively** raise the offline limitation before the buyer does, locating for whom it matters and for whom it does not.

Debrief. Why does disclosing a genuine weakness **raise** credibility here — and what makes the difference between this and a limitation left unlocated?

Answers. (1) Each objection needs one Feel-Felt-Found response (principle: **acknowledge before counter**) and one reframe (principle: **change the frame of comparison**). Model for “too expensive”: FFF — “I understand (feel); other clients felt that comparing sticker prices (felt); what they found was the time saved paid back the gap in months (found)”; reframe — “expensive next to what, including the cost of leaving the problem unsolved?” On the debrief: acknowledging first lowers defensiveness so your evidence is **heard**; an immediate rebuttal signals you are arguing against the buyer, raising defensiveness so the same evidence bounces off. (2) Check that the seller states the price and then **stops**, and that the buyer fills the pause with useful information — a hidden constraint, a softening (“that’s more than we hoped”), or a concession. A model where the seller speaks first has missed the technique and would have conceded before learning anything. (3) A strong answer raises the offline limitation **unprompted**, states plainly that it is a real constraint **for** teams working without signal and a non-issue **for** an office-based team on wifi like this one, and thereby turns the admission into proof of honesty. The difference from a weak disclosure is **locating** it: an unlocated “it can be limited offline” plants a doubt and resolves nothing, while “a problem if X, irrelevant if Y — and you’re a Y” shows you understand the buyer’s situation.

Chapter takeaways. An objection is information about what blocks the yes. React with Feel-Felt-Found (**acknowledge before countering**), reframing (**change the frame of comparison** — the cousin of competitive framing), and strategic silence (**let the other party’s discomfort** draw out information) — naming the principle and choosing the move, never reciting a script, and never talking past the close. Work **proactively** too: raise a predictable concern before the buyer does, and disclose a genuine limitation **located** for whom it matters and for whom it does not — honesty that builds credibility.

5. Sales-Pipeline Economics and Funnel Hygiene

5.1. Selling is a system, not a series of heroics

One salesperson's brilliant close is a story; a **pipeline** is a system you can diagnose and improve. Once a company runs many deals, performance stops being about individual charisma and becomes about the **economics of the funnel**: how opportunities flow through defined stages, where they leak, and which one or two fixes would most raise the end-to-end conversion rate.

5.2. Stages and stage definitions

Ask two reps what “Qualified” means and you get two answers: one counts a friendly reply, the other a signed-off budget. Until the stages mean the same thing to everyone, the pipeline's numbers describe nobody's reality.

Definition 18 (Pipeline and stage definitions). A **sales pipeline** is the ordered sequence of stages an opportunity passes through from first lead to closed deal (e.g. Lead → Qualified → Demo → Proposal → Negotiation → Closed). **Stage definitions** are the explicit, objective criteria that mark entry into each stage — what must be **true** for a deal to count as “Qualified,” not merely how the rep feels about it.

Pitfall. Vague stage definitions are the root cause of an unreliable pipeline. If “Qualified” means “the rep is optimistic,” the forecast is fiction and leakage cannot be located. Every stage needs a **verifiable** entry criterion (e.g. “Qualified = passes BANT, confirmed in writing”). This discipline of accurate, well-defined stages and clean data is **funnel hygiene**.

In practice each opportunity lives as a **record** holding exactly the facts a clean funnel needs: which stage it is in, the qualification behind that stage, its current status, and the next action. Figure 8 shows one.

Meridian Retail — logistics platform		€60,000 / yr
Stage	Proposal	
Qualification (BANT)	Budget approved · Authority: VP Ops (economic buyer) · Need: cut warehouse errors · Timeline: sign by Q3	
Pipeline status	Proposal sent 12 Sep · awaiting buyer response	
Next follow-up	Call the internal champion, 19 Sep	

Figure 8: One opportunity as a CRM record: the stage, the qualification behind it, the pipeline status, and the next follow-up. The same fields are the backbone of tools like HubSpot and Salesforce; here the record only shows what a clean pipeline stage tracks — operating those tools is a separate, out-of-scope skill.

5.3. Conversion, benchmarks, and leakage

Definition 19 (Conversion, benchmark, leakage). **Conversion** (or stage-to-stage conversion) is the fraction of opportunities that advance from one stage to the next. A **benchmark** is a reference conversion rate — historical, peer, or category — to compare against. **Leakage** is the loss of opportunities between stages; the **end-to-end** conversion is the product of all the stage-to-stage rates.

Example — Reading a funnel. A pipeline runs Lead → Qualified → Demo → Proposal → Won with these counts and conversion rates:

- Lead → Qualified: 1000 → 400 (**40%**)
- Qualified → Demo: 400 → 300 (**75%**)
- Demo → Proposal: 300 → 90 (**30%**)
- Proposal → Won: 90 → 45 (**50%**)

End-to-end: $0.40 \times 0.75 \times 0.30 \times 0.50 = 4.5\%$ — 45 wins from 1000 leads. The worst leak by far is **Demo → Proposal** at 30%: two of every three demos die without even producing a proposal. The next-worst is Lead → Qualified at 40%.

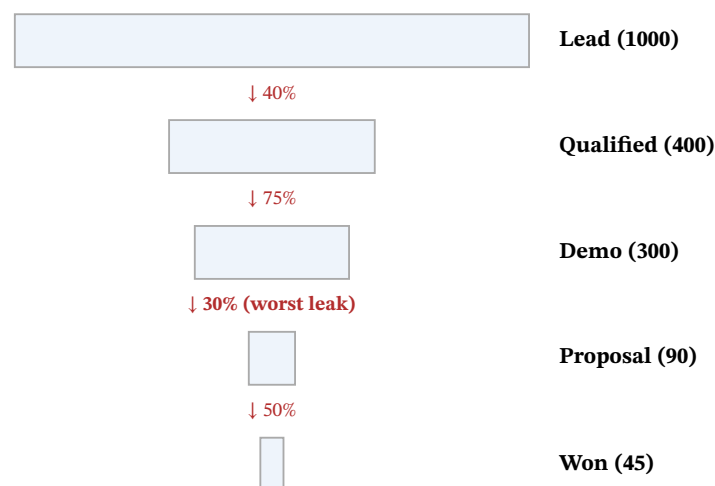


Figure 9: The funnel from the worked example. Each bar’s width is proportional to the number of deals at that stage; each arrow shows the stage-to-stage conversion. The Demo → Proposal step (30%) loses the largest **share**, making it the first lever to investigate.

5.4. Finding the two highest-leverage levers

Diagnosing a pipeline is not “improve everything.” It is finding the **two** stage-transitions where a realistic improvement would most raise the **end-to-end** rate. Here the arithmetic is decisive. Because end-to-end conversion is the **product** of the stage rates, lifting one stage from a current rate r to $r + \Delta$ multiplies the whole product by $(r + \Delta)/r = 1 + \Delta/r$. For a given gain Δ , that multiplier is largest where the current rate r is **smallest**. So a fixed percentage-point gain is worth most at the **lowest-converting** stage — and the raw **number** of deals sitting at a stage does not enter the end-to-end rate at all.

Example — Which lever to pull. Apply the same +10-percentage-point gain to each stage of the funnel above (baseline end-to-end 4.5%) and read off the new end-to-end rate:

- Demo → Proposal, 30% → 40%: $0.40 \times 0.75 \times 0.40 \times 0.50 = 6.0\%$
- Lead → Qualified, 40% → 50%: $0.50 \times 0.75 \times 0.30 \times 0.50 = 5.6\%$
- Proposal → Won, 50% → 60%: $0.40 \times 0.75 \times 0.30 \times 0.60 = 5.4\%$
- Qualified → Demo, 75% → 85%: $0.40 \times 0.85 \times 0.30 \times 0.50 = 5.1\%$

The ranking tracks the **lowest** starting rate exactly — not the volume of deals. The same gain is worth most at Demo → Proposal (30%), then Lead → Qualified (40%). Those two lowest-converting stages are the levers; lifting Demo → Proposal the whole way to 50% raises end-to-end conversion to $0.40 \times 0.75 \times 0.50 \times 0.50 = 7.5\%$ — a two-thirds jump in wins from a single stage.

One refinement tempers the pure arithmetic: the **achievable** Δ differs by stage. A stage sitting far below its benchmark has genuine headroom, while one already at its benchmark may be near its ceiling — so weigh each low-rate stage by how far it lags its benchmark, not only by its rate. What never re-enters the calculation is raw volume: the end-to-end rate is a product of the stage **percentages**, and a stage is not a better lever merely for holding more deals.

Example — When a benchmark overrides the raw rate. The lever choice above assumed the same +10 points were available at every stage. They rarely are — and a **benchmark** (the rate comparable teams reach at that stage) is how you tell where the room actually is. Suppose the same funnel carries category benchmarks:

- Lead → Qualified: 40% (benchmark **40%**)
- Qualified → Demo: 75% (benchmark **78%**)
- Demo → Proposal: 30% (benchmark **55%**)
- Proposal → Won: 50% (benchmark **65%**)

Raw lowest-rate ranking chose Demo → Proposal (30%) and then Lead → Qualified (40%). But Lead → Qualified is **already at its benchmark**: comparable teams do no better, so its realistic headroom is near zero and a +10-point gain there is a fantasy. Proposal → Won, at 50%, lags its 65% benchmark by 15 points — real, evidenced room. Lift each stage only as far as its **benchmark** and recompute the end-to-end rate (baseline 4.5%):

- Demo → Proposal, 30% → 55%: $0.40 \times 0.75 \times 0.55 \times 0.50 = 8.25\%$
- Proposal → Won, 50% → 65%: $0.40 \times 0.75 \times 0.30 \times 0.65 = 5.85\%$
- Qualified → Demo, 75% → 78%: $0.40 \times 0.78 \times 0.30 \times 0.50 = 4.68\%$
- Lead → Qualified, 40% → 40%: no headroom — stays 4.5%

The two levers are now Demo → Proposal and **Proposal → Won** — not Lead → Qualified. The benchmark **overrode** the raw-rate answer: the second-lowest rate turned out to be the stage with the least room to move. The rate tells you where conversion is low; the benchmark tells you where a low rate is actually **fixable**.

Pitfall. Two seductive errors: (1) optimising the stage that is **easiest** to improve rather than the one with the most leverage, and (2) “improving” conversion by **redefining stages** — quietly moving the goalposts so more deals “qualify.” The second is hygiene failure disguised as progress: it flatters the dashboard while the real economics get worse, because unqualified deals now clog the later, more expensive stages.

Remark. The whole funnel is the marketing-allocation logic of *Marketing Fundamentals* turned operational: finite selling capacity must be allocated to the stage where a euro of effort yields the most incremental revenue. Pipeline diagnosis is “How to Allocate” applied to a sales team.

5.5. Running the funnel backwards: from a revenue target to leads

The same product of stage rates that **diagnoses** a funnel also **plans** one. Read forward, it turns a number of leads into wins; read **backwards**, it turns a revenue target into the leads that target demands. Where the forward pass **multiplies** by each rate, the backward pass **divides** by it, stage by stage.

Example — From €900k to the leads it takes. You must land **€900,000** of new business next year, and your average deal is worth **€20,000** — so you need **45 wins**. Run the funnel of the worked example backwards, dividing by each stage’s rate in turn:

- $45 \text{ wins} \div 50\% (\text{Proposal} \rightarrow \text{Won}) = \mathbf{90 \text{ proposals}}$
- $90 \div 30\% (\text{Demo} \rightarrow \text{Proposal}) = \mathbf{300 \text{ demos}}$
- $300 \div 75\% (\text{Qualified} \rightarrow \text{Demo}) = \mathbf{400 \text{ qualified opportunities}}$
- $400 \div 40\% (\text{Lead} \rightarrow \text{Qualified}) = \mathbf{1,000 \text{ leads}}$

So the €900k goal requires **1,000 leads** — exactly the funnel read forward earlier, now derived from the target instead of the top. Forward and backward are one chain of rates run in opposite directions.

Pitfall. Two backward-planning traps. First, **round fractional counts up**: if a stage rate demanded 266.7 qualified opportunities you need 267, not 266 — you cannot half-qualify a deal, and rounding down leaves you short of the target. Second, planning the lead **number** but not the **capacity** to work it: 1,000 leads no one has time to call will convert far below the rates that assumed each got proper attention.

Exercises

5.1. The situation. You have taken over sales operations at a SaaS firm. Last quarter the pipeline ran Lead → Qualified → Demo → Proposal → Won with counts 800 → 280 → 210 → 84 → 42.

What you have. Only these counts; the reps insist “every stage is fine.”

Task. Compute each stage-to-stage conversion and the end-to-end rate, then identify the two highest-leverage levers and justify the choice numerically.

Debrief. Why is the highest-**volume** stage not automatically the best lever?

5.2. The situation. The board sets next year’s new-business target at **€1,200,000**. Your average deal is worth **€30,000**, and you may assume the stage rates of the worked example (40%, 75%, 30%, 50%).

What you have. The target, the deal size, and the rates — nothing downstream yet.

Task. Run the funnel backwards to the wins, proposals, demos, qualified opportunities, and leads the target requires.

Debrief. If your team can realistically source only 800 leads, what has to change for the target to survive?

5.3. The situation. Your CRM lets reps advance a deal to any stage by hand, and the forecast keeps missing.

What you have. Free rein to rewrite the entry rules for “Qualified,” “Proposal,” and “Negotiation.”

Task. Write an objective, verifiable entry definition for each of the three stages.

Debrief. Take one of your definitions, make it vague, and explain how that vagueness would corrupt the funnel’s diagnosis.

5.4. The situation. A sales manager boasts that “qualification conversion” jumped from 40% to 70% in a single quarter and wants a bonus for it.

What you have. The dashboard number and access to the underlying deal data.

Task. Give two innocent explanations for the jump and one that should worry you, and say what data would tell them apart.

Debrief. Which downstream metric is hardest to fake, and why does it settle the question?

5.5. The situation. Your funnel runs Lead → Qualified → Demo → Proposal → Won at stage rates **30%, 45%, 70%, 50%**. Your industry association publishes category **benchmarks** for the four stages: **60%, 47%, 72%, 75%**.

What you have. The four rates and the four benchmarks — nothing else.

Task. Rank the stages as improvement levers **two ways**: first by raw rate alone, then by how far each rate lags its benchmark. Name the two highest-leverage levers on the benchmark-aware view, and say which stage the raw-rate view would have chosen by mistake.

Debrief. Why is a low conversion rate at a stage already sitting at its benchmark a poor lever, even though its rate is among the lowest?

Answers. (1) Rates: $280/800 = 35\%$, $210/280 = 75\%$, $84/210 = 40\%$, $42/84 = 50\%$; end-to-end $0.35 \times 0.75 \times 0.40 \times 0.50 = 5.25\%$. Add the same Δ (say +10 points) to each candidate and recompute: the largest new end-to-end appears at the **lowest** rates, because the product scales by $1 + \Delta/r$. The two levers are Lead → Qualified (35%) and Demo → Proposal (40%), adjusted for how far each lags its benchmark. The highest-volume stage is not automatically best because raw counts never enter the end-to-end product — only the percentages do. (2) $\text{€}1,200,000 \div \text{€}30,000 = 40$ **wins**; $\div 50\% = 80$ **proposals**; $\div 30\% = 267$ **emos** (266.7 rounded up); $\div 75\% = 356$ **qualified** ($267 \div 75\%$); $\div 40\% = 890$ **leads** ($356 \div 40\%$). At only 800 leads the target cannot hold on volume alone — you must raise a stage rate (e.g. improve the 30% Demo → Proposal step) or the deal size, or accept a lower target. (3) For example: **Qualified** = passes BANT with budget and decision-maker confirmed in writing; **Proposal** = a written, priced proposal has been sent and the buyer has acknowledged receipt; **Negotiation** = the buyer has responded and price or terms are under active discussion. Vague “Qualified = the rep is hopeful” swells the Qualified count with unready deals, so Qualified → Demo looks falsely low and the real leak is hidden. (4) Innocent: better lead sources/targeting, or genuinely sharper qualification. Worrying: the bar for “Qualified” was quietly lowered (goalpost-moving). Look downstream — **wins per lead** is hardest to fake: if qualification truly improved it holds or rises, but if the goalposts moved, later-stage rates fall while wins-per-lead stays flat or drops. (5) Raw-rate ranking picks the two lowest rates: Lead → Qualified (30%) and Qualified → Demo (45%). But the benchmark lags are 30, 2, 2 and 25 points, so Qualified → Demo (45% against a 47% benchmark) has almost no headroom, while Proposal → Won (50% against a 75% benchmark) lags by 25. Lift each stage only to its benchmark and recompute end-to-end (baseline $0.30 \times 0.45 \times 0.70 \times 0.50 = 4.73\%$): Lead → Qualified reaches $0.60 \times 0.45 \times 0.70 \times 0.50 = 9.45\%$, Proposal → Won reaches $0.30 \times 0.45 \times 0.70 \times 0.75 = 7.09\%$, and the other two stay under 5%. The two real levers are **Lead → Qualified and Proposal → Won**; the raw-rate view would have chosen Qualified → Demo as the second lever by mistake. A low rate already at its benchmark is a poor lever because the benchmark is evidence that comparable teams do no better there — the achievable Δ is near zero, and since leverage is $1 + \Delta/r$, a Δ of zero buys nothing however small r is.

Chapter takeaways. A pipeline is a system of defined stages with verifiable entry criteria; keeping those definitions and the data clean is funnel hygiene. Stage-to-stage conversion, compared to benchmarks, locates leakage, and end-to-end conversion is the **product** of the stage rates. Because it is a product, a fixed percentage-point gain is worth most at the **lowest**-converting stage; diagnose by finding the two lowest-converting transitions (weighed by how far each lags its benchmark) — not by chasing the highest-volume step. Run the chain **backwards** — dividing by each rate — to turn a revenue target into the wins, proposals, qualified opportunities, and leads it requires. And never “improve” conversion by redefining stages to flatter the numbers.

6. Value-Based Pricing Conversations

6.1. From the price to the price conversation

Marketing Fundamentals taught value-based pricing: set the number to the value the customer perceives, not to your cost. This chapter is about the **conversation** in which that value is claimed across the table — where anchoring, concession design, and packaging decide how much of the value you actually capture. The strategy sets the target; the conversation determines the realisation.

6.2. Anchoring the conversation

Put €60,000 on the table first and the haggling orbits €60,000; let the buyer open at €30,000 and it orbits €30,000 — the same service, a different centre of gravity, fixed by whoever named a number first. The opening figure quietly sets the range everything after it moves within.

Definition 20 (Anchoring in a price conversation). **Anchoring** is opening with a reference number that shapes the counterpart's expectations for the whole negotiation, because of the anchoring bias (Chapter 2): the final figure is pulled toward the first one stated. A well-chosen opening anchor — ambitious but justifiable — pulls the settlement in your favour; a timid one caps your upside before the conversation begins.

Example — The cost of a weak anchor. Two consultants price the same project, worth roughly €200k of value to the client. Consultant A, afraid of scaring the client, opens at €25k and settles at €22k. Consultant B opens at €60k — high, but well within the value it creates and defensible by it — and settles at €42k. Same work, same client; B captured nearly twice as much, almost entirely because of where each **started** the conversation. The anchor did most of the work.

Pitfall. Anchor on **value**, not on cost, and make the anchor **defensible**. An anchor with no justification (“€60k because we feel like it”) collapses the moment it is challenged and damages credibility. An anchor tied to the value the client stands to gain (“€60k against the €200k this will save you”) holds under pressure. And beware the **buyer's** anchor: when they open low, do not negotiate down from their number — re-anchor against your own.

6.3. Concession design

You will rarely hold your anchor exactly; you will concede toward a settlement. Drop from €60k to €52k to €48k to €46k — shrinking steps — and the buyer senses a floor approaching. Drop €60k, €52k, €44k, €36k — even steps — and they learn that pushing always wins another chunk, so they keep pushing. **How** you concede signals as loudly as the numbers themselves.

Definition 21 (Concession design). **Concession design** is the planned sequence and **size** of your price moves. Concessions should **diminish** in size as you approach your floor, signalling that room is running out, and ideally be **traded** (given only in exchange for something) rather

than given freely. Random or **increasing** concessions invite the counterpart to keep pushing, because each move tells them more is available.

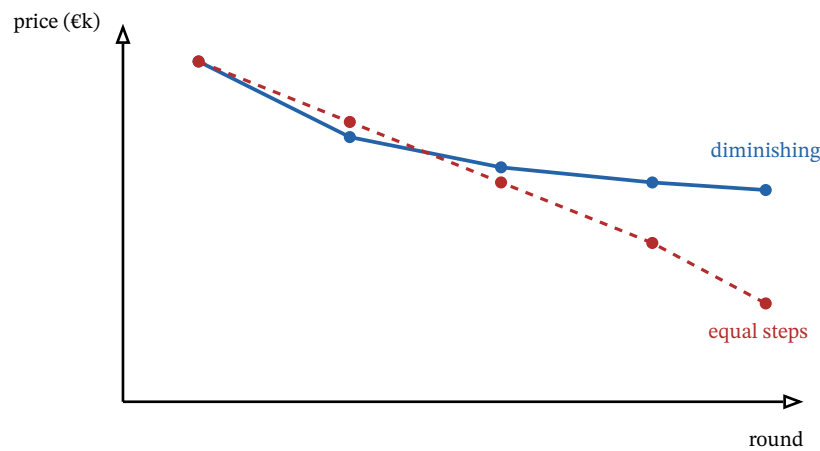


Figure 10: Two concession paths from the same anchor. Diminishing steps (solid) signal an approaching floor and settle high. Equal or growing steps (dashed) signal that more is always available, inviting the buyer to keep pushing — and settle far lower.

Example — Trading concessions. Instead of simply dropping price, tie each concession to a return: “I can come down to €52k **if** we move to a 2-year term,” then “€48k **if** you pay quarterly in advance,” then “I can do €46k, but that’s the floor — and only with the public reference.” Each concession is smaller than the last (signalling the floor) and **buys something** (term, cash flow, marketing), so price drops are recovered elsewhere. This is integrative bargaining (Chapter 1) inside the price conversation.

6.4. Package vs line-item

Quote “everything included, one price” and the buyer cannot pick your offer apart — but cannot see the value packed inside it either. Itemise every component and you can show that value and quietly drop the one line they object to — but you invite a grind over each remaining line. One offer, two framings, opposite risks.

Definition 22 (Package vs line-item pricing). **Package pricing** quotes one bundled number for the whole offer; **line-item pricing** itemises each component with its own price. The trade-off: packaging **obscures** component costs and resists itemised discounting (the buyer cannot pick at individual lines), but reduces transparency and can hide value the buyer would have paid for; line-item pricing is **transparent** and lets you show value, but invites component-by-component negotiation (“we don’t need this line, take it off”).

Example — Choosing the framing. Selling an implementation project: a **package** “€90k, everything included” prevents the buyer from stripping out the (high-margin) training and support lines and stops a line-by-line grind. But if the buyer’s main objection is “we already have our own trainers,” **line-item** framing lets you remove that line visibly, preserve the rest, and show exactly what they are paying for. The right choice depends on whether you most fear **unbundling**

pressure (then package) or most need to **demonstrate value and flex on specific components** (then line-item).

Pitfall. There is no universally “better” framing — stating the trade-off is the point. Defaulting to line-item with a buyer who loves to haggle invites a slow erosion of the price, one line at a time; defaulting to a package with a buyer who needs to justify each line internally can kill the deal on opacity. Choose deliberately, and be ready to switch framing if the objection reveals the other pressure.

Structuring a value-based pricing conversation for a named account thus means three deliberate choices: a defensible value **anchor**, a **concession path** that diminishes and trades, and a **package-vs-line-item** framing — each chosen with its trade-off stated aloud.

Exercises

6.1. What the buyer knows. You run a mid-size retailer. A consultancy has pitched a project you privately estimate will save you around €200,000 a year. You intend to push hard on price.

What the seller knows. Your floor for the project is €40,000, and you can flex on term length, payment timing, and being named as a public reference.

Task. Write the opening anchor, justify it by **value** (not cost), and design a three-step concession path in which the steps **diminish** and each is **traded** for something.

Debrief. Why should the last concession be flagged as the floor, and what signal would an **increasing** concession path send the buyer?

6.2. What the buyer knows. You already employ your own trainers, so you resent paying for training you will not use — but you cannot judge the rest of the offer line by line.

What the seller knows. Training and support are your highest-margin lines; the buyer loves to haggle item by item.

Task. Present the same offer once as a **package** and once as **line items**. State which buyer objection each framing handles better and the trade-off each framing accepts.

Debrief. Given this particular buyer, which framing would you actually open with, and why?

6.3. What the buyer knows. You open with an aggressive lowball — €18,000 for the same €200,000-value project — hoping to drag the settlement down.

What the seller knows. €18,000 is below your floor and detached from any value basis.

Task. Describe concretely how the seller avoids being dragged down by the lowball and re-anchors the conversation.

Debrief. Why is negotiating **down from** the buyer’s number a mistake even when you hold firm on your floor?

Answers. (1) No single key — check that the anchor is justified by the **value** created for the client (not by cost), that the three concessions **shrink** in size, and that each one **buys something** (a longer term, earlier cash, a reference). The last step should be flagged as the floor. (2) The **package** framing best handles unbundling and line-by-line haggling (the buyer cannot strip out individual lines) at the cost of transparency; **line-item** best handles a “we don’t need line X” objection and lets you demonstrate value, at the cost of inviting a component-by-component grind. A complete answer names **both** trade-offs, not just which framing wins. (3) Do not counter from their number. Name it as an opening tactic, mentally discard it, restate the value basis, and re-anchor with your own prepared, value-justified figure — or decline to counter at all until the extreme is withdrawn (“that’s not a serious basis; here’s where the value actually sits”).

Chapter takeaways. Value-based pricing sets the target; the price conversation realises it. Open with a defensible **value** anchor (and re-anchor against the buyer's lowball rather than negotiating down from it). Design concessions to **diminish** and to be **traded**, never given freely. Choose **package** framing to resist unbundling or **line-item** to demonstrate value and flex on components — and state the trade-off of whichever you pick.

7. Client Relationship Management over Time

7.1. The deal is the beginning, not the end

Everything so far has aimed at closing. But in most businesses the first sale is the **least** profitable transaction you will ever have with a client: acquisition is expensive, while renewals, expansion, and referrals from an existing happy client are cheap. The economics of *Marketing Fundamentals* — a brand and a customer base as compounding **assets** — apply directly to the individual account. This chapter covers managing a client relationship over its life, in four elements.

7.2. The four elements of a CRM plan

One client signs, hears nothing for eleven months, then gets a renewal invoice — and leaves. Another is guided to a first win within a week, checked in on each month, and offered more only when their usage shows they need it — and renews for years. Same product; the difference is entirely in how the relationship was managed, across four elements.

Definition 23 (Client relationship management over time). Managing a client relationship covers four elements:

- **Onboarding** — bringing a new client to their first real value as quickly and smoothly as possible.
- **Follow-up cadence** — the regular, deliberate rhythm of contact after the sale (not only when something is wrong or you want to sell more).
- **Upsell triggers** — the observable signals that indicate a genuine opportunity to expand the account.
- **Conflict-resolution protocol** — the defined procedure for handling disputes before they end the relationship.

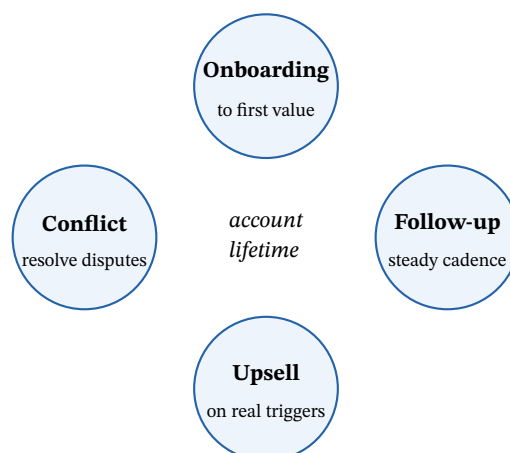


Figure 11: The client-relationship lifecycle. Onboarding earns the first value; a steady follow-up cadence sustains trust; upsell triggers expand the account; a conflict protocol protects it. The loop repeats over the account's life.

7.3. Onboarding: time-to-first-value

Example — Why onboarding decides retention. A SaaS company finds that clients who reach their “first successful report” within seven days renew at 90%, while those who take over a month renew at 40%. The product is identical; the difference is **onboarding**. The fix is to engineer the path to first value — a guided setup, a check-in call on day three, a template that produces a win immediately — because the early experience, not the contract, sets the trajectory of the whole relationship.

7.4. Follow-up cadence

Pitfall. The commonest relationship failure is the **only-when-selling** contact pattern: the client hears from you at signing, then silence, then a renewal email asking for money. By then there is no relationship to renew. A deliberate cadence — scheduled check-ins, value reviews, useful touches that ask for nothing — maintains the trust that renewals and upsells depend on. Cadence is regular **by design**, not triggered only by your needs.

7.5. Upsell triggers

A client emails to say they are opening a second office and doubling their team. **That** is the moment to propose more seats — it answers a need they have just announced. Pitch the same seats “because it’s renewal season,” with no such signal, and it is only pressure.

Definition 24 (Upsell triggers). **Upsell triggers** are observable signals that the client has a genuine new need you can serve — hitting a usage limit, hiring into a team that would use more seats, launching in a new region, repeatedly requesting a feature in a higher tier. A trigger-based upsell serves a real, surfaced need; an untriggered one (“it’s renewal season, let’s push the premium tier”) is just pressure and erodes trust.

Example — A triggered upsell. A client’s usage dashboard shows they have hit 95% of their plan’s capacity three months running, and they have twice asked support about a feature in your enterprise tier. **That** is the moment — and the justification — to propose the upgrade: it solves a problem they are visibly already feeling. The trigger makes the upsell a service, not a sales push.

7.6. Conflict-resolution protocol

A billing error double-charges a key client. With a protocol in place, the account manager already knows who the client calls, how fast to acknowledge it, and that she can refund on the spot — so a tense moment becomes a demonstration of reliability. Without one, the client waits days for “someone to look into it” and starts shopping around.

Definition 25 (Conflict-resolution protocol). A **conflict-resolution protocol** is a pre-agreed procedure for handling disputes — a missed deliverable, a billing error, an outage: who

the client contacts, how fast you acknowledge, who has authority to make it right, and how the resolution is confirmed. Defined **before** a conflict arises, it turns a relationship-threatening moment into a demonstration of reliability.

Example — A conflict handled well. A service outage costs a key client a day's work. With a protocol in place: the account manager acknowledges within the hour (not after legal review), apologises plainly, states what happened and what is being done, and applies a pre-authorised remedy (service credit) without a fight. Handled this way, the outage can **strengthen** the relationship — the client learns they can rely on you when things go wrong. Handled defensively, the same outage ends it.

A relationship-management plan specifies all four elements for a **named** account: exactly how the client is onboarded, at what cadence they are contacted, which observable triggers will prompt an upsell, and the steps of the conflict protocol — concrete enough to act on, not generic intentions.

Exercises

7.1. What the client knows. You have just signed a €40,000/year contract for an analytics tool. You are busy, mildly anxious you overbought, and will judge the tool by whether it produces something useful in the first weeks.

What the account manager knows. Clients who reach first value fast renew far better; you control onboarding, cadence, upsell timing, and how conflicts are handled.

Task. Write a one-page CRM plan for this named account covering all four elements: a concrete onboarding path to a first value (with a timeframe), a specific follow-up cadence, at least three **observable** upsell triggers, and a step-by-step conflict-resolution protocol.

Debrief. Which single element most protects the renewal, and why?

7.2. What the client knows. (Two clients of the same product.) One reached a first successful report within seven days; the other took over a month. Both have the same features available.

What the vendor knows. The fast client renews at 90%, the slow one at 40%.

Task. Explain why “time to first value” predicts retention better than the product’s features do, using this evidence.

Debrief. If features do not explain the gap, what does — and what does that imply about where to spend effort?

7.3. What the client knows. You have quietly hit 95% of your plan’s capacity three months running and twice asked support about an enterprise-tier feature.

What the account manager knows. Renewal season is also approaching, and there is pressure to push the premium tier to everyone.

Task. Distinguish a **triggered** upsell from an **untriggered** one with a concrete example of each for this client, and explain why the difference matters for long-term trust.

Debrief. What observable signal turns a “push” into a “service” here?

Answers. (1) No single key — check all four elements are present **and concrete** for the named account: an onboarding path to a specific first value (with a timeframe), a scheduled follow-up cadence that is not only-when-selling, at least three **observable** upsell triggers, and a step-by-step conflict protocol (who the client contacts, how fast you acknowledge, who can make it right, how the fix is confirmed). Generic intentions fail; specifics pass. (2) The onboarding example shows an identical product with opposite renewal rates (90% vs 40%) split only by time-to-first-value: the early experience sets the trajectory of the whole relationship, so a client who reaches value fast stays regardless of

the feature list — and features cannot retain a client who never reached value. (3) A **triggered** upsell answers an observable real need (usage at 95% of capacity, repeated requests for a higher-tier feature) and reads as service; an **untriggered** one (“it’s renewal season, push the premium tier”) is pressure with no surfaced need. The difference matters because untriggered pushes erode the trust that renewals, expansion, and referrals all depend on.

Chapter takeaways. The first sale is the start of the profitable relationship, not the end. Manage it across four elements: **onboarding** to fast first value (which predicts retention), a deliberate **follow-up cadence** (not only-when- selling), **upsell triggers** tied to observable real needs (not renewal-season pressure), and a **conflict-resolution protocol** defined before trouble strikes. A plan names all four concretely for a specific account.

8. Multi-Party and Team Negotiation; Advanced Tactics

8.1. When the table gets crowded

Everything so far assumed two parties. But put three firms around a table to share one warehouse, where any **two** of them could proceed without the third, and the deal is no longer a single negotiation — it is a contest over **who allies with whom**, a dimension that does not exist when only two sit down. Real high-stakes deals — alliances, procurement, M&A, multi-party tenders — involve more than two parties, or **teams** on each side, and the extra parties do not just scale the difficulty; they change its **kind**, introducing coalitions, internal coordination, and a richer toolkit of tactics and countermoves.

Definition 26 (Multi-party and team negotiation). **Multi-party negotiation** involves three or more parties, which introduces **coalitions** (subsets that align to swing the outcome) and **shifting majorities** — so managing who allies with whom can matter more than any single bilateral exchange. **Team negotiation** involves several negotiators on one side, requiring **internal coordination**: agreed roles, a single position, and discipline so the other side cannot split the team.

Pitfall. The signature danger of **team** negotiation is being **divided**: a skilled counterpart addresses the most pliable member, exploits a visible disagreement, or plays your team's members against each other. Before the table, agree roles (who leads, who takes notes, who watches the room), a single position, and a rule that concessions come only from the lead — never improvised by an individual member under pressure.

Case study — A three-way supply alliance. Three firms are negotiating to jointly fund and share one warehouse. Sharing saves **€900k a year** in total; the fight is over how to split that saving and the running costs. Each firm brings something different, and any **two** can proceed without the third by covering the shortfall — so every pair is a possible coalition.

- **NovaParts** — large and cash-rich; wants control and a long, stable term. Its contribution (cash) is **fungible** — anyone's money is as good as anyone's.
- **Bergen** — mid-size; owns the best-located site to host the warehouse; wants a low upfront outlay.
- **Klar** — small; brings the logistics software that runs the site (worth about **€200k a year** of the total saving); wants a short exit clause and flexibility.

The naïve reading ranks power by size, putting Klar last. But coalitions turn on **complementary** contributions, not size. If NovaParts and Bergen ally (cash + site) and try to exclude Klar, they **lose Klar's software** — €200k of the very saving they are dividing. Klar's walk-away is therefore stronger than its size suggests: its contribution is hard to replace, while NovaParts' cash is not. The lesson of the crowded table: map each party's BATNA and which contributions are **complements** before assuming the biggest player holds the most leverage.

8.2. Advanced tactical moves — and their countermoves

“This price is only good until Friday.” “My colleague is the hard one — I’m on your side here.” “We’ll start at half your number and see.” Each of these is a move designed to work on you, and each has a calm, specific answer. The following tactics are **adversarial**: a counterpart will use them on you, so you must recognise them and, where appropriate, deploy and counter them — and for each, the countermove is more important than the tactic.

Definition 27 (Three advanced tactics and their countermoves).

- **Artificial deadline** — a fabricated time limit to force a hasty decision (“this price is only good until Friday”). **Countermove**: test whether the deadline is real (“what happens if we decide next week?”); a manufactured deadline rarely survives a calm question.
- **Good cop / bad cop** — one negotiator is aggressive, another conciliatory, so you gratefully concede to the “nice” one. **Countermove**: name the routine openly (“you two seem to have different views — sort that out and come back to me”), which dissolves its effect.
- **Aggressive anchoring** — an extreme opening figure meant to drag the settlement toward it. **Countermove**: refuse to treat it as a starting point; re-anchor against your own prepared, value-based number, or decline to counter until the extreme is withdrawn (“that’s not a serious basis for discussion — here’s where value actually sits”).

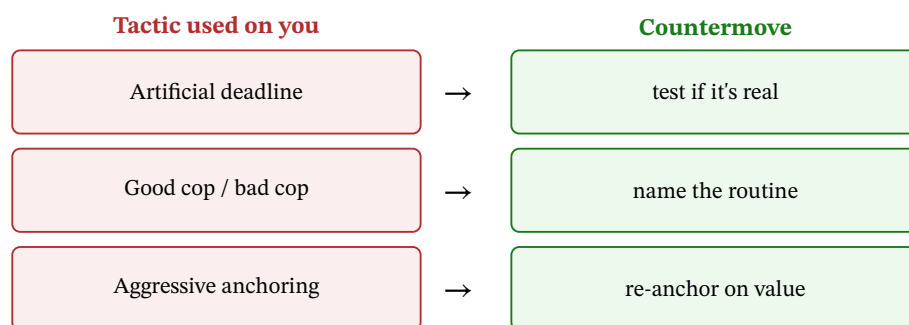


Figure 12: Each advanced tactic has a standard countermove. Recognising the tactic is half the defence; the other half is the calm, specific response that neutralises it.

Example — Countering an artificial deadline. A supplier says, “We can only hold this 20% discount if you sign today.” Rather than panic-signing, you test it: “We’re interested, but we can’t make a six-figure decision by tonight. If the discount truly expires, we understand — we’ll proceed at the standard price next week.” Nine times in ten the deadline softens (“well, let me see what I can do”), revealing it was a pressure tactic, not a real constraint. The countermove cost nothing but composure.

Pitfall. Two ethical limits on these tactics. First, several of them (fabricated deadlines, aggressive anchoring detached from any value) edge toward manipulation — the subject of the next chapter; deploy them knowing the line. Second, the goal is rarely to “win” a single exchange at the cost of the relationship. In any negotiation with a counterpart you will deal with again, win-at-all-costs tactics buy a one-time gain and a lasting enemy.

8.3. The debrief

The day after a hard negotiation, “it went well” teaches you nothing you can reuse. “We conceded exclusivity to lock in the two-year term, and we signed under a deadline we never once tested” teaches you exactly what to repeat and what to fix. A multi-party negotiation is especially hard to learn from in the moment — too much happens at once, under pressure — so what turns the raw experience into transferable skill is the **debrief** afterwards.

Definition 28 (The post-hoc debrief). A **debrief** is a structured after-action review of a negotiation that names, specifically: what was **conceded**, **why** each concession was made, which tactics were used and countered, where value was created versus claimed, and what you would do differently. Its purpose is to convert tacit experience into explicit, transferable judgment.

Example — A debrief entry. “We conceded the exclusivity clause (worth €15k/year to us) to secure the 2-year term we wanted, because our BATNA — a smaller annual deal — was weak and the term protected our capacity planning. We failed to test their ‘board meeting Friday’ deadline and signed under time pressure we should have questioned. Next time: probe the deadline, and lead with an integrative trade on exclusivity rather than giving it away to break the deadlock.” Specific, honest, and transferable — that is the standard.

Exercises

8.1. What each party knows. Three agencies can share one media-buying desk, saving €600k a year between them. Big Co brings the cash, Mid Co brings the client relationships, Small Co brings the only trading software the desk can run. Any two can proceed by covering the third’s shortfall.

What you know as Small Co. Your software is hard to replace; everyone assumes size decides power.

Task. Identify a coalition of two that could form, explain how it changes the outcome for the excluded third party, and say what that third party could do about it.

Debrief. When does a coalition of two actually extract surplus from the third — and when does excluding the third destroy the value the coalition needs?

8.2. What the counterpart knows. You are a supplier who likes to use pressure tactics: a “sign by Friday” deadline, a good-cop/bad-cop pairing, and an extreme opening figure.

What you (the buyer) know. You recognise all three as tactics and have prepared your own value-based number.

Task. For each of the three tactics, write a short script in which the counterpart deploys it and you apply the countermove, naming the countermove principle each time.

Debrief. Why does **naming** a tactic openly tend to neutralise it?

8.3. What you know. You have just finished a negotiation (real or simulated) in which you conceded something, faced at least one tactic, and both created and claimed value.

What the other side knows. Only their side of it — the debrief is for you.

Task. Write a debrief that names what was conceded and why, which tactics appeared, where value was created versus claimed, and one concrete improvement for next time.

Debrief. What makes a debrief **transferable** rather than just “it went well”?

8.4. What each party knows. Take the three-way supply alliance case study above: NovaParts (cash), Bergen (the site), Klar (the software worth €200k of the €900k saving). Each party's private wants are in the case study.

Task. With two other people (or by writing all three parts yourself), assign the NovaParts, Bergen, and Klar briefs and negotiate a split of the €900k saving and the running costs.

Debrief. Which coalition formed, why, and what did the excluded party do about it?

Answers. (1) and (4) have no single key, but a strong answer shows the **coalition of two** extracting surplus from the third only when the two together can replace what the third contributes; when the excluded party holds a **complement** (as Klar holds the software), excluding it destroys value the coalition needs, so its walk-away is strong and it can demand a larger share. The excluded party's best moves: strengthen its BATNA, make its contribution visibly hard to replace, or split the would-be coalition by offering one member a better bilateral deal. (2) Each script should show the tactic, then the calm, named countermove: **artificial deadline** → **test whether it is real** ("what happens if we decide next week?"); **good cop / bad cop** → **name the routine openly** ("you two seem to disagree — sort that out and come back to me"); **aggressive anchoring** → **refuse it as a starting point and re-anchor on your own value-based figure**. Check that the countermove principle is named correctly for each. (3) No single key — a strong debrief is **specific**: it names each concession and the reason for it, the tactics used and faced, where value was created versus claimed, and one concrete change for next time. A vague "it went well" reflection fails the standard, which is honesty and transferability.

Chapter takeaways. More than two parties introduces coalitions and shifting majorities; teams require internal coordination and discipline against being divided. Advanced tactics — artificial deadlines, good cop / bad cop, aggressive anchoring — each have a calm countermove (test it, name it, re-anchor), and the countermove matters more than the tactic. Many tactics edge toward manipulation and most relationships outlast a single deal, so weigh the long game. Close every negotiation with a debrief that names what was conceded and why.

9. Sales Ethics: Persuasion vs Manipulation

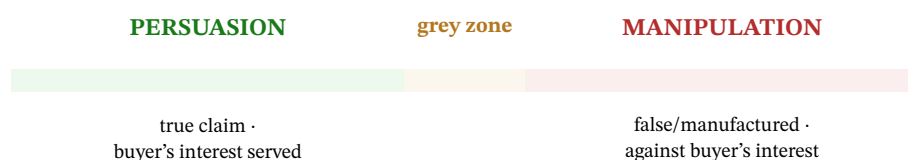
9.1. The line that runs through everything

Almost every technique in this book is dual-use. BATNA can be honestly improved or bluffed about; Cialdini's principles can serve a buyer or trap one; anchoring can reference real value or a fictional list price; scarcity can be true or manufactured. This final chapter draws the line the whole course has been circling — because a professional is defined not by knowing the tactics but by knowing when **not** to use them.

9.2. Defining the line

A seller who cites a real, relevant qualification to reassure a buyer is persuading; one who invents a credential or drapes themselves in an authority they do not hold is manipulating. From the outside the move looks the same — an appeal to expertise — but one rests on truth and serves the buyer, and the other does neither. That gap is the whole subject of this chapter.

Definition 29 (Persuasion vs manipulation). **Persuasion** presents true information and genuine value, calibrated to the interlocutor's own interests, leaving them better off for having said yes. **Manipulation** exploits a principle or bias to induce a decision **against** the interlocutor's interests — typically through deception, or by manufacturing a false sense of reciprocity, scarcity, authority, or social proof. The mechanics can be identical; the difference is **truth** and **whose interest is served**.



Tests: Is the claim true? · Would the buyer thank you if they knew everything you know?

Figure 13: Persuasion and manipulation sit on one spectrum with the same mechanics. Two tests locate any move on it: is the underlying claim **true**, and is the buyer's **genuine interest** served?

Example — The same principle, both sides of the line. Scarcity. “Only three seats left on this course” — **true**, and it helps a genuinely interested buyer decide in time: persuasion. The identical sentence when there are forty seats — **false**, engineered to panic the buyer: manipulation. **Reciprocity.** A genuinely useful free audit that creates goodwill is persuasion; a “gift” engineered solely to manufacture obligation for something the buyer does not need is manipulation. **Anchoring.** Opening against a real comparable cost is persuasion; inventing a “€2,000 value, today €200” where nothing ever sold at €2,000 is manipulation. In each pair the **technique** is the same; truth and the buyer’s interest decide which side of the line it falls.

9.3. Two practical tests

Was that “sign by Friday” deadline actually real? And would the buyer, knowing everything the seller knew, still be glad they said yes? Ask those two questions of almost any move and its ethics resolve.

Definition 30 (Two tests, and the three verdicts). To locate any move on the spectrum, ask two questions:

1. **The truth test** — is the underlying claim true? (Is the deadline real? the scarcity genuine? the social proof factual?)
2. **The interest test** — would the buyer, knowing everything you know, still be glad they said yes?

The pair of answers gives the verdict. **Persuasion:** both tests pass — a true claim that serves the buyer’s genuine interest. **Manipulation:** either fails — a false or manufactured claim, or a true one exploited to push the buyer **against** their own interest, so that their consent depends on their **not** knowing what you know. **Grey zone:** the two tests **conflict** or you cannot honestly answer one of them — most often a claim that is literally true but whose service to the buyer’s interest is doubtful, or a case where the truth itself is uncertain. The grey zone is not a comfortable place to operate: treat a move that lands there as a signal to stop and get clear, not as licence to proceed.

Pitfall. Manipulation is not only an ethical failure; in any repeated game it is a **strategic** one. A manipulated buyer who later discovers the truth churns, warns others, and destroys the compounding client relationship of Chapter 7. Cialdini’s principles are a double-edged tool: the edge that wins a manipulated sale this quarter is the same edge that severs the relationship next year. Honesty is not merely virtuous here — over time, it is more profitable.

Example — Why the manipulator loses the long game. A salesperson hits quota by manufacturing urgency and overstating fit. Deals close fast — and churn faster: refunds, bad reviews, a reputation that makes the **next** sale harder. A colleague who qualifies honestly (BANT), discovers real needs (SPIN), and only sells where the fit is genuine closes fewer deals this month and many more over two years, because each happy client renews, expands, and refers. The economics of Chapter 7 and the ethics here point the same way.

Remark. This is why the course teaches judgment, not just tactics — exactly as *Marketing Fundamentals* argued that the durable skill is the judgment AI cannot commoditise. Anyone can learn to anchor, to invoke scarcity, to run good-cop/bad-cop. The scarce, durable professional skill is knowing, in the moment, which moves serve the relationship and which betray it — and having the discipline to decline the betrayal even when it would close the deal.

9.4. Using the levers in the open

Every technique in this book is a lever, and every lever can lift or crush. The commercial judgment this course set out to build is, finally, the judgment to use them in the open — to create value before claiming it, to serve the interlocutor’s real interest, and to win in a way that leaves you someone the

other side wants to deal with again. That is what makes the difference between a salesperson who closes once and a professional who is trusted for a career.

Exercises

9.1. What the buyer knows. You are shopping for online-course seats and are sensitive to both urgency and social proof.

What the seller knows. You can invoke any of Cialdini's six principles, and each can be run on a true footing or a manufactured one.

Task. For each of the six principles, write one **persuasive** use (true claim, buyer's interest served) and one **manipulative** use (false or against-interest) of the same principle — keeping the mechanic identical across each pair.

Debrief. In each pair, what exactly flipped the move from persuasion to manipulation?

9.2. What the buyer knows. (You are the buyer.) You can recall three real sales or advertising tactics that were used on you.

What the seller knew. Whether each underlying claim was true, and whether your genuine interest was served — some of which you can reconstruct, some not.

Task. Apply the two tests (truth, interest) to each of the three tactics and classify it as persuasion, grey zone, or manipulation, justifying the call from the two test outcomes.

Debrief. For any you placed in the grey zone, what one fact would you need to move it out of it?

9.3. What the buyer knows. Nothing yet about which seller is honest — you will discover it only over time, through use, refunds, and word of mouth.

What the two sellers know. One manufactures urgency and overstates fit to hit quota; the other qualifies honestly and sells only where the fit is genuine.

Task. Argue, with reference to the client-relationship economics of Chapter 7, why manipulation is a poor **strategy** and not merely an ethical lapse. Walk a concrete two-year scenario.

Debrief. At what point in the two years does the honest seller overtake the manipulator, and why?

Answers. (1) No single key — check twelve uses, two per principle, with the **mechanic identical** across each pair: the persuasive use rests on a **true** claim serving the buyer's interest, the manipulative twin on a **false or manufactured** version (or one against the buyer's interest). Example for scarcity: "three seats left" when true versus the same line fabricated to panic the buyer. (2) Apply **both** tests and read off the verdict: both pass → persuasion; either fails through deception or against-interest exploitation → manipulation; the tests conflict or you cannot honestly answer one (a literally true claim whose service to the buyer's interest is doubtful) → grey zone. The justification must cite the two test outcomes, not a gut feeling. (3) A sound answer walks a two-year path: the manipulator closes fast but suffers churn, refunds, and a reputation that makes the next sale harder, while the honest seller compounds renewals, expansion, and referrals from each satisfied client — so over the horizon of Chapter 7 the honest strategy wins on the numbers, not only on ethics.

Chapter takeaways. Persuasion and manipulation share the same mechanics; they differ in **truth** and **whose interest is served**. Locate any move with two tests: is the claim true, and would the buyer be glad they said yes knowing what you know? Every technique in this course is dual-use, and in any repeated game manipulation is also a strategic loss — it destroys the compounding client relationship. The professional's defining skill is the judgment to decline the manipulative move even when it would close the deal.

Primary sources and further reading

The frameworks in this book come from a small number of primary works. To go deeper, read the originals:

- **Roger Fisher, William Ury & Bruce Patton — Getting to Yes.** The Harvard Negotiation Project: BATNA, interests versus positions, and principled, value-creating negotiation (Chapter 1).
- **Robert Cialdini — Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion.** The six principles of influence and the evidence behind them (Chapter 2).
- **Daniel Kahneman — Thinking, Fast and Slow.** Anchoring, framing, and loss aversion, from the work with Amos Tversky (Chapter 2).
- **Neil Rackham — SPIN Selling.** The four question types, derived from analysis of thousands of real sales calls (Chapter 3).
- **AIDA** is a classic advertising model attributed to E. St. Elmo Lewis in the late nineteenth century; any marketing-communications text covers it (Section 3.5).